

Articles for Reading



Book 2

30 Articles – B2+ Level

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Articles in this book has been compiled by Mikhida Khakimova

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FAR RIGHT PARTIES ON THE RISE IN EUROPE

The last few years have seen a **rise** of **far right** parties in Europe. These right-wing parties often have Christian **values** and follow **nationalist movements** in their countries. They are against **immigration** and some of them are **anti-EU**.

Europe's far right parties have their own section inside the European Parliament. Among the most **prominent** are France's National Front, led by Marine Le Pen, Italy's Lega Nord, The Dutch Party of Freedom and Austria's Freedom Party.

Recently, Austria's Freedom Party **candidate** Norbert Hofer almost became the country's first far right president, but lost **narrowly** to a green candidate. The Freedom Party was already in **government** once, between 2000 and 2006.

Many other countries in Europe are **witnessing** the rise of far right parties. Sweden, for example, has taken a **liberal stance** on immigration and allowed more **refugees per capita** into the country than any other European nation. As a result **polls** show that **support** for the right wing Sweden Democrats has risen to 25%.

One of the strongest right-wing **movements** is in Hungary, where conservative Prime Minister Viktor Orban has been **forced** to move more and more to the right, under the **pressure** of the extreme Jobbik Party. Last year, he **dealt** with the refugee problem in his own way by building a **much-criticised fence** around Hungary's **borders**.

Many political experts see German **chancellor** Angela Merkel as one of the reasons for a rise in support for the far right. Last year she **announced** that the country would welcome all refugees that wanted to come to Germany. She is **strongly** criticized by the Alternative for Germany, a new right-wing party that almost **made it** into parliament in 2013.

Many people in Europe are **attracted** right wing movements across the continent. As refugees from the Middle East and Northern Africa are coming to Europe in masses, **citizens** feel their countries **threatened** and jobs taken away from them. There is **growing concern** that the EU does not have a **solution** for the refugee problem, thus **leading** to increasing **Euro-scepticism** in almost all EU countries.

Words

- **announce** = to officially say something
- **anti-EU** = against the European Union
- **attract** = to make people interested in something
- **border** = line between two countries
- **candidate** = person who wants to be elected for an official position in a country
- **chancellor** = leader of the government
- **citizen** = person who lives in a country and has rights there
- **deal with** = manage, find a solution for a problem
- **Euro-scepticism** = a feeling that the EU is not good for the people; you want to be more independent as a country and not have the EU always telling you what to do
- **fence** = structure, like a wall, that can be made out of different materials

- **far right parties** = political parties that are very conservative
- **force** = to make someone do something
- **government** = the people who rule a country
- **growing concern** = more and more people are worried
- **immigration** = when people come to a country from other countries in order to live and work there
- **lead** = cause
- **liberal stance** = to be very liberal and not old-fashioned in your views
- **made it** = here: to get into
- **movement** = campaign; actions by a group of people
- **much-criticized** = when many people do not agree with what you do
- **narrowly** = only by a few votes
- **nationalist** = person who wants their country to be politically independent
- **per capita** = based on the number of people living in a country
- **poll** = a study in which people are interviewed and asked about their opinion on a subject
- **pressure** = to try to make someone do something by threatening them
- **prominent** = well-known, famous
- **recently** = a short time ago
- **refugee** = a person who has escaped from their home country out of political or religious reasons
- **right-wing** = very traditional and conservative
- **rise** = to become more and more
- **solution** = way to handle a problem
- **strongly** = very much
- **support** = to be for something
- **threaten** = here: to believe that it will be bad for you
- **value** = what someone believes in
- **witness** = see, observe

BOKO HARAM – ISLAMIC TERRORISTS IN NIGERIA

Boko Haram is an Islamic terrorist **movement** that **operates** out of north-eastern Nigeria. There are up to 10 000 members of the group, which wants to **establish** an Islamic **state** in Nigeria. Boko Haram is also **thought to have connections** with al Qaeda and the Islamic State.

The organization has been active since 2009, killing more than 5000 **civilians**, **mainly** in Nigeria's Northern provinces. In the last five years Boko Haram have **kidnapped** hundreds of men, women and children, **including** some western tourists. By 2014 over half a million people have **fled** from the conflict zone to neighbouring countries.

Boko Haram was **founded** in 2002. **Violence** started **increasing** in 2009 when its **founder** was killed. Since then the terrorist group has carried out **numerous** attacks on police buildings and other **governmental** organizations. **Targets** include **politicians** and religious leaders. In 2011 Boko Haram a car bomb exploded in a UN office in the **capital**, Abuja, killing 21 people.

The Islamic movement has been in control of a **territory** of about 50,000 square kilometres in northern Nigeria. Boko Haram is also active in neighbouring Chad, Niger and northern Cameroon. Islamic fighters **escape** the Nigerian army by **retreating** to these countries. The army's **attempt** to fight Boko Haram has not been **successful**. The country's **armed forces** are short of money. Some **officers** and **soldiers** are corrupt and **sympathise** with Boko Haram.

Boko Haram is a **fundamentalist** movement that follows the **sharia**. It is against western **values**, **especially** education, and wants Nigeria's poor people to **receive** a part of the country's **oil revenues**. Since 2000, the sharia has been introduced by **local authorities**, mostly in the Islamic north of the country.

Since Nigeria became **independent** from Great Britain in 1960 the country has been **ruled** by civilian governments as well as military **dictators**. The country is **split** between the poor Islamic north and the **wealthier** Christian south. In the past few years northern politicians have become **strongly** sympathetic to Boko Haram and other Islamic groups.

Although Boko Haram has a **hierarchical** structure, the organization operates in **cells** with a few hundred fighters each. The terrorists get their money from kidnappings and are also **funded** by Islamic-friendly governments. **Drug trafficking, smuggling and rhino poaching** are other **sources of income**.

Words

- **armed forces** = army
- **capital** = the main city of a country; where the government is
- **cell** = group, unit
- **civilian** = a person who is not in the army
- **connection** = link, relationship
- **dictator** = person who has complete power over a country; in most cases they are not elected

- **drug-trafficking** = buying and selling drugs
- **escape** = get away from
- **establish** = start, begin, set up
- **flee-fled** = escape
- **found-founded** = start something new
- **fund** = get money from
- **fundamentalist** = someone who has very strict religious beliefs
- **government** = the people who rule a country
- **hierarchical** = ordered
- **including** = also
- **increase** = to go up
- **kidnap** = to take someone and hold them prisoner in order to get money for returning them
- **local authorities** = the government or council that rules a small part of the land
- **mainly** = mostly
- **movement** = organization, group
- **numerous** = many
- **officer** = someone who is in a high position in the army, air force or navy
- **oil revenues** = the money that a country gets from selling oil
- **operate** = work out of ...
- **politician** = someone who works in politics or in the government
- **receive** = get
- **retreat** = move back to
- **rhino poaching** = to hunt rhinos illegally and sell their valuable horns
- **sharia** = Islamic law
- **smuggling** = take something illegally from one country to another
- **soldier** = person who fights for a country
- **source of income** = place where you get money
- **strongly** = very much
- **successful** = here: if something works the way you want it to
- **sympathise** = to support someone and help them
- **target** = a person that is to be attacked
- **territory** = land
- **thought to have** = people think that ...
- **value** = idea
- **violence** = fighting

GAZA – ISRAEL CONFLICT

The violent **battle** between Israel and Palestinians in Gaza is part of the Arab-Israeli conflict, which has been going on for decades. After Israel was **founded** in 1948, millions of Palestinians **fled** their homelands and **settled** in the West Bank and the Gaza Strip. At that time, Gaza belonged to Egypt. In 1967, Israel **occupied** the area after the 6-Day War. In the **decades** that followed, **several** conflicts have **arisen** between Palestinians and Israelis.

The Gaza Strip is a 25 mile-long area on the Mediterranean **coast**. Most of its 1.8 million people live in extreme **poverty**. **Infrastructure** is weak; food and **electricity** are often **scarce**. Over 40% of the Palestinians are **unemployed** because they cannot find any work in Gaza. Some of them travel across the **border** to work in Israel.

The United Nations **manages** almost half of the schools in Gaza, but more are needed to **deal with** the **rise** in population, which is expected to grow to over 2 million by 2020. The UN also says that more and more houses and apartments are needed for people who have lost their homes during Israeli **air strikes**.

In 2005, Israel decided to **withdraw** their **army** from the Gaza Strip in an **attempt** to allow Palestinians to **rule** themselves. It also **pulled out** 5000 Israelis, who **settled** in the region. **Shortly afterwards**, a terrorist organization called Hamas took power after winning **general elections**. Hamas does not **recognise** Israel as a **sovereign** state and wants to destroy the Jewish country. Its **aim** is to give Palestinians their old **homeland** back.

In the last few years, Israel has **led** an **all-out** war against Hamas. It controls what gets in and out of Gaza at the **border crossings** in the east and north. Israel has set up land and sea **blockades** to protect itself and controls the **airspace** over Gaza. Egypt has closed its own border with Gaza because it is afraid that hundreds of thousands will **flee** to the Arab country.

Hamas does not have a regular army, however terrorists **constantly** fire rockets into Israel, mostly from a system of tunnels that they have built. This **draws** Israel more and more into an **armed** conflict, **seeking revenge** for Israeli civilians who have been killed. Israel's **airstrikes** have not only destroyed Hamas' military **command posts** but also killed thousands of **innocent civilians**.

Western countries, **including** the United States and the European Union have been working hard at **achieving** a peaceful way to **solve** the crisis. One **solution** would be to turn Gaza and the West Bank into a **sovereign** Palestinian state; **however**, this is **rejected** by Israel, as long as Hamas controls much of the region.

Words

- **achieve** = reach, do
- **airspace** = the sky over a country
- **airstrike** = attack a place from the air
- **all-out** = with a lot of energy
- **arise – arose – arisen** = come up, start
- **armed** = with guns, rockets and other things used to fight in a war

- **blockade** = when you put soldiers or ships in a place to stop people or goods from getting in or out
- **border** = line between two countries
- **border crossing** = place where you can travel from one country to another
- **civilian** = person who is not a soldier or in the army
- **coast** = place where land meets the sea
- **command post** = place from which military leaders control a fight or war
- **deal with** = manage
- **draw** = pull
- **electricity** = power that is in wires or cables and is used to make light and heat
- **flee – fled** = escape from a dangerous situation
- **found – founded** = to start something new; here: to create a new country
- **general election** = when all of the people in a country vote for a government or parliament
- **homeland** = home; place where you or your family have lived for a long time
- **infrastructure** = systems that a country needs in order to function, for example roads, bridges, schools, hospitals etc..
- **innocent** = harmless
- **lead – led** = here: fight
- **manage** = control, run, operate
- **occupy** = to enter a country and control it with an army
- **poverty** = the situation of being poor
- **pull out** = take out of
- **recognise** = accept
- **reject** = to say no; to be against something
- **revenge** = something you do to punish a person or group that has attacked you
- **rule** = govern
- **scarce** = limited, not enough of
- **seek** = look for
- **settle** = to move to another place and live there
- **several** = many
- **shortly afterwards** = a short time later
- **solution** = answer, way out of a problem
- **solve** = find an answer to something
- **sovereign** = independent, free
- **unemployed** = out of work
- **withdraw** = pull out of an area



ISRAEL SETTLEMENTS

Since Israel **occupied** the West Bank, East Jerusalem and the Golan Heights during the Six Day War of 1967 they have been building **settlements** for Jewish settlers in this region. There were also new towns in Gaza but Israel called all settlers back in 2005. **Although** the **peace accord signed** with the **PLO** in Oslo **prohibited** the building of new settlements the Israeli **government** is continuing to **grant** their construction.

The international **community regards** these settlements as **illegal** and the United Nations has **repeatedly condemned** the Jewish state for building them. The Jewish settlements in the **occupied territories** are one reason why peace talks between Israel and the Palestinians are at a **standstill**. Amnesty International and other **human rights** organizations **argue** that constructing settlements on the Palestinian **territory** is a **violation** of human rights.

Today, about 350 000 settlers live in over a hundred settlements in the West Bank. Another 300,000 live in East Jerusalem, 20,000 live on the Golan Heights. Some of the settlements are **recently** built small cities with their own **infrastructure**, **urban** services and transportation; others have been built in the **suburbs** of big cities like Hebron. Recently the Israeli government has **authorized** the construction of four new settlements in the occupied West Bank.

Originally the Jewish settlements were constructed in order to stop Palestinians from **obtaining** their own state and to **establish** a **buffer zone** between Israel and its Arab neighbors.

Settlers have largely come to the region for **economic** reasons. Israel's government offers certain bonuses to people who are willing to settle there. **Goods** produced in the West Bank and East Jerusalem are **subsidized** by the government. **Tax cuts** and other economic **incentives** motivate Israelis to move to the occupied territories. On the other side there are religious fanatics who believe they are returning to their **biblical** homeland. They regard Arabs as **aliens** in their country.

Most new settlers **enjoy** the **advantages** of their new home. While Israeli settlements offer jobs to Palestinians who would **otherwise** be **unemployed**, there is regular **tension** between settlers and Arabs.

Many settlements are built on the best farming land. Palestinians **accuse** Israelis of **consuming** too much water and leaving them only little. Reports of violence on the side of settlers who **lash out** at Palestinians are not **uncommon**.

The future of the Jewish settlements is only one **issue** that needs to be **resolved** in order to achieve a **lasting** peace agreement in the Middle East. Other issues are the future of Jerusalem and the **borders** between Israel and a new Palestinian state.

Words

- **accuse** = blame; to say something is your fault
- **advantage** = the good side of something
- **alien** = foreigner
- **although** = while
- **argue** = to disagree with someone; to give clear reasons about your opinion

- **authorize** = allow
- **biblical** = written in the Bible
- **border** = line between two countries
- **buffer zone** = area that protects you from enemies
- **community** = here: all the people in the world
- **condemn** = criticize; to say that something is wrong
- **economic** = about industry, trade and money
- **establish** = create
- **goods** = products
- **government** = the people who rule a country
- **grant** = allow
- **human rights** = the basic rights that everyone should have
- **incentive** = something that gives you a reason to work harder or do something
- **infrastructure** = schools, hospitals, roads etc.; things that a city needs to exist
- **lash out** = to show anger towards someone
- **lasting** = permanent
- **occupy** = to enter a place with an army and take control of it
- **originally** = at first
- **otherwise** = or else
- **peace agreement** = a document that ends a conflict or a war
- **PLO** = Palestine Liberation Organization = political group of Palestinians who want their own state
- **prohibit** = ban, stop, not allow
- **regard** = look upon, consider
- **resolve** = solve, decide
- **settlement** = group of houses or buildings in a place where not many people have lived before
- **sign** = to put your name on a document
- **standstill** = stop, not go on
- **subsidize** = when the government gives money to a company to produce something
- **suburb** = area of the city that is far away from the centre
- **tax cuts** = lower taxes
- **tension** = conflict, problems
- **uncommon** = here: happen often
- **unemployed** = without work
- **violation** = action that is against the law

NUCLEAR WEAPONS

The **nuclear weapons** race started at the end of World War II when the United States dropped two atomic bombs over Japan. Since then **several** countries have produced their own nuclear **devices** and others are working hard on their production.

The United States

Nuclear testing began during World War II and ended in the early 1990s after the collapse of Communism. The United States still has the most **operational warheads** (over 2000), while there are still thousands that are being **dismantled**. The Americans also have nuclear weapons stationed in other NATO countries. Together with Russia, the US is the only member of the atomic weapons club that has air-, sea- and land-**based** nuclear weapons. For two **decades** the United States has been working together with Russia to **reduce** the number of nuclear weapons around the world.

Russia

Russia **conducted** its first nuclear test in 1949, four years after the Americans bombed Hiroshima and Nagasaki. During the **Cold War** the **arms race** led to a **proliferation** of nuclear weapons. Today, Russia has about 1,700 operational warheads. Nuclear experts, however, are worried that after 1990 some warheads might have fallen into the hands of third parties and are thus, not **accounted for**.

Great Britain

The UK joined the nuclear club in 1951 and has about 160 warheads that can only be **delivered** by submarines.

France

France is the third largest nuclear power after the US and Russia. The country can fire its 300 warheads either from air or sea.

China

Communist China started a nuclear program in the 1950s after the United States moved some of their own warheads to Asia during the Korean War. **Currently** China can **deploy** land- and air-based missiles, and may **shortly** be able to put them on submarines.

India

India tested its first nuclear weapon in 1974 because it saw neighboring China and Pakistan as a major **threat** to the region. India has land and air based weapons that can be made operational **at short notice**.

Pakistan

After conflicts and regional wars with India in the last forty years Pakistan tested its first warhead in 1998 and is said to have 100 warheads.

Israel

Although Israel has never **confirmed** the testing of atomic weapons, experts believe that the country has had a nuclear weapons program for decades. Israel probably has at least 80 missiles on land that can deliver nuclear warheads.

North Korea

In the last few years North Korea has been conducting **underground** tests. Western experts think that the Communist state has enough **plutonium** to build atomic bombs but they doubt whether it can deliver them on missiles. **Sanctions** against the country **took effect** some years ago after talks to stop the program had **failed**.

Iran

The western world is also worried about Iran's plans to build a nuclear bomb. The International Atomic Energy Commission **claims** it has **serious proof** that Iran is producing plutonium to build a bomb. Iranian leaders have **repeatedly** said that they are only **enriching** uranium for nuclear energy. The United Nations has put **sanctions** on the country in an attempt to stop Iran's program.

Several other states at one time had a nuclear weapons program or already had produced warheads. States of the **former** Soviet Union, including Ukraine and Kazakhstan **possessed** nuclear warheads when the country broke apart, but returned them to Russia in the following years. South Africa developed nuclear weapons during the **Apartheid** years but stopped it in the 1990s. Saddam Hussein was thought of **developing** his own nuclear weapons in Iraq. In 2003 the United States invaded the country because they thought the dictator had **weapons of mass destruction**. Argentina, Brazil and South Korea stopped their nuclear weapons programs many years ago.

Words

- **account for** = here: to say where they are
- **although** = while
- **Apartheid** = the political and social system of South Africa in the 20th century; whites had all the power and other groups, especially blacks were forced to live in separate areas, go to separate schools etc..
- **arms race** = when two or more countries compete for the largest number of weapons
- **at short notice** = within a short time
- **based** = here: to be fired from
- **Cold War** = the unfriendly relationship between the Soviet Union and the United States after World War II
- **conduct** = carry out
- **confirm** = to show that something is true
- **currently** = right now
- **decade** = ten years
- **deliver** = transport
- **deploy** = set up; make something work
- **develop** = produce, make, plan
- **device** = here: bomb
- **dismantle** = take apart

- **enrich** = here: to increase the number of atoms so that a substance can produce more power
- **fail** = not succeed
- **former** = earlier, ex-
- **nuclear weapon** = powerful bomb that uses nuclear energy to kill many people and destroy large areas
- **operational** = ready, working
- **plutonium** = radioactive metal that is used to produce nuclear weapons
- **possess** = own, have
- **proliferation** = increase; large number
- **proof** = evidence, facts
- **reduce** = lower
- **repeatedly** = over and over again
- **sanction** = order to stop trade or punish a country in certain ways to force their leaders to change their political opinion
- **serious** = real
- **several** = many
- **shortly** = in the near future
- **threat** = danger
- **took effect** = start
- **underground** = under the surface of the Earth
- **warhead** = the front part of a missile that explodes when it hits something
- **weapons of mass destruction** = chemical, nuclear or biological weapons that are very dangerous and can kill thousands of people



KASHMIR

Kashmir is a mountainous region in the Himalaya Mountains between India and Pakistan. It has been a conflict region for over 60 years, ever since the Indian subcontinent became **independent**.

In 1947, after Great Britain had **withdrawn** from south Asia, India and Pakistan became independent countries. The **Maharaja** of Kashmir **decided** to become a part of India, **in return for** Indian **protection**. In the past 60 years India and Pakistan have fought three wars over the region.

Although there has been **less** violence in the region **recently**, it is still a trouble spot. A **minor** conflict could **trigger** a war between India and Pakistan, both nuclear powers in the region.

Kashmir is the only region within India with an Islamic **majority**. Many people do not want to be **governed** by India. They want to become a part of Pakistan or be independent altogether. The people think that they are being **discriminated against** by the government in Delhi. **Unemployment** is running high and they **claim** they are not getting the help they need.

In the 1990s there have been many **incidents** along the **borderline** in Kashmir between Indian and Pakistani **armed forces**. However, in the last **decade**, there have been **signs** of **improving** relationships. In 2006 Pakistan stopped giving money to **paramilitary** groups fighting in Kashmir and two years ago India **announced** that it would **grant amnesty** to Pakistani **freedom fighters**.

Today Kashmir is controlled by three countries. The east and south with a population of 9 million are controlled by India; Pakistan **administers** the north and the west, while China also controls a small region.

Many **officials** in both India and Pakistan want peace, because both countries are tired of the decade long conflict. They also think that a **lasting** peace will bring **stability** and economic **growth** to a **war-torn** region. But in both countries there are extremist groups that do not want their governments to give in and make peace.

Words

- **administer** = govern, control
- **although** = while
- **amnesty** = to let prisoners go free
- **announce** = to say officially
- **armed forces** = army
- **borderline** = where two countries meet
- **claim** = to say that's something is true
- **decade** = a period of ten years
- **decide** = choose
- **discriminate against** = to treat someone in an unfair way or differently from someone else

- **freedom fighter** = person who wants their country or land to become independent
- **govern** = rule
- **grant** = give
- **improve** = get better
- **in return for** = in exchange for
- **incident** = events, things that happen
- **independent** = free
- **less** = not that much
- **Maharaja** = an Indian prince or king
- **majority** = most of the people in a group
- **minor** = small
- **paramilitary** = illegal group that is organized like an army
- **protection** = guard, security
- **recently** = in the last few years
- **sign** = signal
- **trigger** = start
- **unemployment** = the situation of being out of work
- **withdraw** = pull back, get out of



REFUGEES

Refugees are people who have **fled** from their country because of wars, political or religious conflicts or because they **fear persecution** from **governments**. **Displaced** people have lost their home but they **remain** in their own country.

Officially there are about 12 million refugees today. The **peak** was **reached** during the Balkan conflict of the 1990s, when almost 18 million people were refugees. About 70 % of the world's refugee population is in Africa and the Middle East.

Over 800,000 people **flee** from their homes and become refugees every year. Most of them **escape** wars and conflicts in Africa and the Middle East. During 2011 thousands fled from North African **dictatorships** during what was called the Arab Spring. During 1994 hundreds of thousands of Rwandans escaped the **genocide** and terror in their country.

Afghanistan is the country with the most refugees, almost 3 million. Most Afghani refugees go to Pakistan. Germany is home to over 500, 000 Afghan **citizens** and over a quarter of a million have come to the United States.

Over one million people have left Iraq and Somalia. Sudan and Congo have about half a million refugees each. The United Nations also **states** there are over 10 million **stateless** people around the world, Kurds or Palestinians who do not belong to a **certain** country.

People do not become refugees only because of war or other political conflicts.

As **drought** continues in the **Horn of Africa** over 12 million people are thought to be homeless or in **refugee camps**.

On the whole over 40 million people are **considered** to be homeless worldwide, **according to** the United Nations, mostly because of new conflicts . They are **likely** to stay refugees and not be able to go back to their homelands any time soon.

Who is a Refugee?

International **law** defines a refugee as a person who has **fled** from their homeland and cannot come back for many reasons. They are **protected** by the Geneva **convention**, which makes sure such people are not **forced** to return to the country they have fled from.

Protecting refugees around the world is done by the UNHCR (UN High Commissioner for Refugees). The organization tries to help them get back to the country of their **origin**, if possible. It also helps them **seek asylum** or **integrate** in the country they have fled to. Many countries do not always give refugees the same rights that they give their **legal citizens**.

Today, it is hard to keep refugees **apart** from economic **immigrants**, those who leave their home country **voluntarily** to go somewhere else in search of a better life and more **income**.

Major refugee movements in history

Refugees have always been a part of history. In the Middle Ages people became refugees because they did not **agree** with the religion of their country. Roman Catholics made **Jews** leave Spain, French Catholics **expelled** Protestants from France.

During the Russian Revolution about 1.5 million people left their country because they were against Communism. Over a million Armenians fled Turkey because they were **in fear of being persecuted**.

By the end of World War II there were over 50 million refugees and **displaced** people in Europe alone. Many were Jews who fled Nazi leaders in Germany. Germans also had to leave areas where they had **settled** before the war.

When a Communist government **took over** China in 1949 two million people fled to Hong Kong and Taiwan. In 1947 almost 20 million Muslims and Hindus had to **cross** borders between India and the new state of Pakistan.

After World War II over 3 million East Germans escaped to West Germany. The **movement** was **halted** in 1961 when the Berlin Wall was built.

Words

- **agree** = to share the same opinion
- **apart** = separate
- **certain** = special
- **citizen** = a person who lives in a country and has rights there
- **considered** = thought
- **convention** = written document that gives someone rights
- **cross** = move
- **dictatorship** = a country in which one person rules without a parliament
- **displaced** = here: if you have lost your home and have to move somewhere else in your own country
- **drought** = a long period of dry weather with little or no rain
- **expel** = to drive out of
- **fear** = to be afraid of
- **flee – fled** = escape from a dangerous situation
- **force** = have to
- **genocide** = the mass murder of a whole group of people
- **government** = the people who rule a country
- **halt** = stop
- **Horn of Africa** = the part of East Africa that includes Somalia and some of Ethiopia
- **immigrant** = a person who leaves their country and go to another country
- **in fear of** = afraid
- **income** = the money you get for the work you do
- **integrate** = mix with other people
- **Jew** = person whose religion is Judaism
- **law** = the rules of a country
- **legal** = lawful
- **likely** = probably

- **movement** = here: people who wanted to do the same things or had the same ideas
- **officially** = formally
- **origin** = starting point; where you come from
- **peak** = the highest point
- **persecution** = to treat someone unfairly or in a violent way, because they think differently or have a different religion
- **protect** = defend, guard
- **reach** = get to, arrive at
- **refugee camp** = a place where refugees can stay for some time
- **remain** = stay
- **seek asylum** = to ask another country if you can live there because you had to leave your own country because of political reasons
- **settle** = to start living in a place
- **state** = to say officially
- **stateless** = without belonging to a country
- **take over** = start controlling
- **voluntarily** = out of your own free will



MYANMAR

Myanmar, once called Burma, has been one of the most **isolated** countries in the world. **However**, since March 2011, when Myanmar's first **civilian government** in **decades** took office, it has been moving **towards** democracy, if only one small step at a time.

After **decades** of **authoritarian rule**, Myanmar's **military** has decided to **step down** from power. Most generals have **realized** that the country has, **economically**, fallen behind their neighbors. They have decided to open themselves to the western world and end the economic **sanctions** that have been **in place** for some time. Many **citizens** in Myanmar, however, are **skeptical**. They think that once the country has been **accepted** in the west the political **tide** will turn against them.

In the last 5 decades Myanmar has developed into one of the most **backward** countries in Asia. Its people are among the poorest. Schools do not have enough teachers and some universities have been closed because of possible student **unrest**. Buildings need to be **repaired**, most of the **infrastructure** is old-fashioned and goes back to British **colonial rule**. Many Burmese **fled** the country and are living in **exile** somewhere else.

All over the country **signs** of democracy have **emerged**. Hundreds of **political prisoners** have been set free. Myanmar's **media** has **received** more freedom, **although** it is still controlled by the **government**.

The government is allowing **trade unions** to form. **Environmental** and **human rights** organizations have sprung up all over the country. People are not **scared** of the military any more. They actually believe in democratic reforms and that their life is about to change **for the better**.

The military leaders have **released** Myanmar's most **prominent** opposition leader, Aung San Suu Kyi, from **house arrest** after 15 years. She is a very **popular** figure in the country, **mainly** because her father was one of the **founders** of the Burmese army and was killed shortly before the country got its **independence** from Great Britain in 1948. She won the Nobel Peace Prize for her fight against military leaders in 1991. The opposition leader hopes that the military will help her change the face of Burma.

Aung San Suu Kyi wants to wake up her people and tell them that the time has come to take **responsibility** for their future. Her party, the National League for Democracy, was not allowed to take part in the **general election** of 2010 but will play a role in **future** elections in Myanmar.

Of the many problems that face the new government in Burma, two **stand out**. For over 15 years Myanmar's leaders have been looking to China for help, **especially** after economic sanctions had been placed on them. Chinese businessmen and companies have invested **heavily** in Myanmar. And the Chinese have also **supplied** the **military junta** with **weapons**. In return the Chinese were allowed to build a **vital** pipeline through Myanmar, which transports oil and gas back to Central China.

Myanmar has **strained** its relationship with China, **especially** after a **contract** for a **hydroelectric power station** near the China-Burmese border had been **signed**. Critics say that most of the electricity will go to China while Burma itself will profit only **little**. On the other side China has warned Myanmar not to **open up** too much to western influence.

Another problem that the government **faces** is the conflict with its **ethnic minorities**, which make up a third of the **population**. Political experts **claim** that peace and **stability** will come to the Southeast Asian country only if it can settle the **disputes** with its minorities.

Even though there are **signs** of Myanmar's new direction towards democracy, many things need to be done before the west is willing to invest large **amounts** of money in the country. Mobile phone connections **lag** behind, the Internet is very slow and banking system is **out-of-date**. Railroads, airports and roads **desperately** need **overhauling**. But western countries, **nevertheless**, are keeping an eye on Myanmar. It has oil and gas reserves, as well as **timber** and **valuable** metals. With a population of 60 million it is one of the big markets in Asia.

Words

- **amount** = sum
- **authoritarian rule** = a government that tells people what to do and punishes them if they do not obey the laws, especially those that are wrong or unfair
- **backward** = developing very slowly or not at all
- **citizen** = a person who lives in a country and has rights there
- **claim** = to say officially
- **colonial rule** = when a European country controls an area far away
- **contract** = a written agreement
- **desperately** = very much
- **dispute** = conflict, problem
- **economically** = about the economy
- **emerge** = come up
- **ethnic minority** = a group of people of a different race from the main group who lives in a country
- **exile** = a situation in which you must leave your country for political reasons
- **face** = deal with
- **for the better** = to improve
- **founder** = a person who started something
- **future** = coming
- **general election** = an election in which all the people of a country can vote
- **heavily** = very much
- **house arrest** = to be kept as a prisoner in your own house
- **human rights** = the basic rights that everyone should have, like the right to vote or the right to say what you want
- **hydroelectric power station** = a building that produces electricity from water power
- **in place** = in effect

- **independence** = freedom
- **infrastructure** = basic systems that a country needs, like transportation, schools, banks etc...
- **isolated** = cut off
- **lag** = here: not as good as
- **little** = not very much
- **media** = radio, television and newspapers
- **military** = army
- **military junta** = government of army officers who have not been elected by the people
- **nevertheless** = but
- **open up** = here: when you let the people have more rights and freedom
- **out-of-date** = not modern; something that should not be used anymore
- **overhaul** = changes that have to be made in order for something to work
- **political prisoner** = someone who is locked up because they have opposed the government or have criticized it
- **prominent** = famous
- **realize** = to find out
- **release** = to set free
- **responsibility** = to be in control and make decisions
- **sanction** = an official order that stops trade between two countries, as a way of forcing a country's leaders to make political changes
- **sign** = mark, signal
- **sign** = to put your name on a document
- **skeptical** = doubtful, not sure
- **stability** = the situation of being stable; not change
- **stand out** = are most important
- **step down** = give up; let someone else take over
- **strain** = to cause problems
- **supply** = provide, give
- **tide** = here: the way in which people's opinions are developing
- **timber** = trees that produce wood
- **towards** = in a certain direction
- **trade union** = organization that represents workers and their rights
- **unrest** = conflict
- **valuable** = expensive, important
- **vital** = very important

ARAB SPRING

A **wave** of demonstrations and protests has been going on in many Arab countries of the Middle East and Northern Africa since the end of 2010.

Revolutions have taken place in Tunisia and Egypt. In both Arab countries leaders had to **resign** and **transfer** their power. In Libya a **civil war** went on for months in an **attempt** to **overthrow** Muammar Gaddafi. In many other Arab countries, like Bahrain and Syria there have been **uprisings** against the **government**.

The protests, which became known as “Arab Spring”, started in Tunisia in December 2010. After the Tunisian president Ben Ali had **fled** the country Egypt’s **population** saw that such a rebellion could be **successful**. After an 18 day protest against **long-time** President Hosni Mubarak, Egypt’s president finally **resigned** and turned power over to the **military**.

In February protests **erupted** in Libya. Rebels who were against Gaddafi and his regime **gathered** in Benghazi and created a new **government**. The Libyan dictator **refused** to **step down** and used the **air force** and army in an **all-out civil war** against the rebels. A UN **resolution** gave NATO the **authorization** to fly over Libya and make sure Gaddafi’s fighter planes do not **attack** rebels. After months of fighting the Libyan dictator was finally overthrown and killed.

Protests in Arab nations have **erupted** for many reasons. Many countries have dictators who have been in power for **decades**. Corruption is **widespread** and basic **human rights** are often **violated**. In some countries the government has not shared the money from oil with the population, who continues to live in **poverty**. Many young people who have taken part in protests have studied in western countries and know what real democracy is.

In contrast to earlier protests the rebellions of 2010 and 2011 have been better organized because of **social networks** like Facebook or Twitter. The opposition planned their protests on these and used YouTube to send images and videos out to the rest of the world.

The **unrest caused** by the protests in Arab countries has led to **economic** troubles as well. Oil and food prices have **risen** dramatically. Economic **growth** in the region is also expected to **decline**.

Words

- **air force** = part of a country’s military that uses airplanes to fight
- **all-out** = using a lot of energy
- **attack** = use violence against
- **attempt** = try
- **authorization** = the right to do something
- **civil war** = conflict between two groups of people in the same country
- **decade** = a period of ten years
- **decline** = to go down
- **economic** = financial
- **erupt** = come up, break out

- **flee-fled** = escape to another place
- **gather** = come together
- **government** = the people who rule a country
- **growth** = to expand, become bigger
- **human rights** = the basic rights that everyone should have, like the right to vote or to say what you want
- **in contrast to** = compared to
- **long-time** = for many years
- **military** = army
- **overthrow** = bring down, defeat, win against
- **population** = the people who live in a country
- **poverty** = the state of being poor
- **refuse** = do not want to
- **resign** = step down, give up power
- **resolution** = decision, declaration
- **rise** = go up
- **social network** = group of people who have the same interests and communicate on internet platforms
- **successful** = do well, work
- **transfer** = give to someone else
- **unrest** = conflict, fighting
- **uprising** = revolt, rebellion
- **violate** = to do something that is against an agreement; to disobey
- **wave** = series
- **widespread** = common, general



OSAMA BIN LADEN

Osama bin Laden was the **founder** of the terrorist organization al Qaeda. He was made **responsible** for the terrorist attacks on the World Trade Centre in 2001 and for bomb attacks in many places around the world. Bin Laden was once a **citizen** of Saudi Arabia but criticized the Arab country for being America's **ally**. Bin Laden was America's most wanted person and has been a **major** target of the USA's war on terror. On May 1, 2011 President Obama **declared** that United States forces had killed bin Laden in a villa in Pakistan.

Childhood and education

Osama bin Laden came from a **wealthy** Saudi Arabian family. His father was a **well-respected** businessman. After school he studied **economics** and **business administration** at the university but it is not clear whether he **earned** an academic **degree** or not. Bin Laden married his first wife at the age of 17. Together with his other three wives he is said to have up to 25 children.

Beliefs and ideology

From his youth on Osama bin Laden was always interested in religion. He was against all western systems and ideologies and said that living by the **Sharia law** was the only form of Islam. He **sympathised** with the Taliban **regime** in Afghanistan because they had a very conservative and radical **view** of Islam.

Bin Laden not only **threatened** America because they had gotten **involved** in the Islamic world but also was truly **anti-Semitic**. On many **occasions** he **stressed** the need to **eliminate** Israel and give Palestine back to the Arabs.

Mujahedeen in Afghanistan

During the Soviet **invasion** and **occupation** of Afghanistan in the 1980s bin Laden joined the **Mujahedeen**. During this period the United States **supported** the freedom fighters and gave them financial **aid** to help **defeat** the Soviets. Bin Laden helped with the money he had **inherited** from his Saudi family.

Formation of Al Qaeda

Although nobody knows exactly when al Qaeda came to life **it is thought** that the group was **founded** as an Islamic **faction** in 1988. He **recruited** mostly Mujahedeen fighters as members of the group.

In the 1990s bin Laden criticised his home country Saudi Arabia for letting American soldiers on Islamic **soil**. The Saudis had **agreed** to **accept** American help in order to fight against Saddam Hussein. For bin Laden, being **dependent on** the western world was **unacceptable**.

After being **expelled** from Saudi Arabia he lived in **exile** in Sudan for a few years and during the mid 1990s went back to Afghanistan. With the help of the new Taliban regime bin Laden **raised** money and created new training camps for Mujahedeen fighters.

Al Qaeda bombings

Terrorist **activities** by Al Qaeda started in the 1990s. Bin Laden **funded** most of them including attacks in Luxor, Egypt killing 60 people and the bombing of the American **embassy** in Nairobi killing over two hundred.

Towards the end of the **millennium** it was clear that al Qaeda was the **major** terrorist **threat** in the world. Bin Laden **officially declared** America the enemy of the **Jihad** and called for all Muslims to join in a holy war against the west.

After 9/11

After the terrorist attacks on America in September 2001 it took the FBI and the CIA only weeks to find out that bin Laden was **responsible**. In October 2001 the United States **launched attacks** on Afghanistan and al Qaeda training camps. **Although** they **deposed** of the Taliban regime they **failed** in **capturing** bin Laden, who was probably hiding in a **cave** complex in the Afghan mountains.

When Barack Obama became president in 2008 he **announced** that the United States would be sending more troops to Afghanistan in an **attempt** to destroy al Qaeda **strongholds**. He also made it clear that the United States was putting **effort** into finding bin Laden, who was still **at large**. He was also **seeking** help from the Pakistani **government** because bin Laden might be hiding neighbouring Pakistan.

Death of bin Laden

On May 1, 2011 a team of American **Special Forces** attacked a **mansion** near Pakistan's **military academy** about a hundred kilometres north of Islamabad. Bin Laden and three other people, including one of his sons, were killed. The Americans took **possession** of his body and **dumped** it into the Arabian Sea. After the **announcement** of bin Laden's death hundreds of thousands of people all over the world **celebrated**.

Words

- **accept** = take on
- **activity** = action
- **agree** = to say yes
- **aid** = help, support
- **ally** = friend
- **although** = while
- **announce** = to say officially
- **announcement** = official message for the people
- **anti-Semitic** = someone who hates Jewish people
- **at large** = to be free
- **attack** = to use weapons against an enemy
- **attempt** = try
- **business administration** = how to organize and lead companies
- **capture** = to take a person prisoner
- **cave** = a natural hole in a mountain
- **celebrate** = to be happy and have a party
- **citizen** = a person who lives in a country and has rights there



- **declare** = to say officially, speak out
- **defeat** = to win against in a war
- **degree** = a qualification that you get when you have finished college or the university
- **dependent on** = to need something very much
- **depose** = to get rid of
- **dump** = throw
- **earn** = get
- **economics** = the study of the way in which money and goods are produced
- **effort** = attempt, try
- **eliminate** = destroy
- **embassy** = a group of people who work for the government of their country in another country, or the building they work in
- **exile** = a situation in which you must leave your country and live somewhere else
- **expel** = to send away
- **faction** = group, party
- **founder** = person who starts something new
- **fund** = to pay for something
- **inherit** = to get money from your family after they have died
- **invasion** = to march into a country with soldiers and take control
- **involve** = engage, be a part of
- **it is thought** = people think that
- **Jihad** = holy war fought by Muslims
- **launch** = start
- **mansion** = very large house
- **military academy** = a college or school where young men are trained to become officers
- **millennium** = a thousand years
- **Mujahedeen** = Muslim soldiers with strong religious beliefs
- **occasion** = event, time
- **occupation** = to keep control of a country by force
- **officially** = to say something so that many people can hear it
- **possession** = ownership, control
- **raise** = collect
- **recruit** = to get people to become a member
- **regime** = a government that is not elected and very often does not have the support of the people
- **responsible** = in control of, to give orders to

- **seek** = look for, want
- **Sharia law** = system of religious rules followed by Muslims
- **soil** = ground, place
- **Special Forces** = soldiers who have been trained to fight against terrorists
- **stress** = to point out a statement or idea
- **stronghold** = a place where a group defends itself
- **support** = help
- **sympathise** = understand, support, like
- **threat** = danger
- **threaten** = warn , terrorize
- **towards** = near
- **unacceptable** = it is wrong
- **view** = attitude, feeling
- **well-respected** = admired and liked by many people because of the good things you have done



AMAZON.COM

Amazon.com is the world's largest Internet company. It started out as an online bookstore in the middle of the 1990s and grew **gradually** over the years. Today Amazon sells almost everything from CDs and DVDs to **sportswear** and electrical **appliances**. The company also produces its own **tablets** and e-readers and lets users upload their own photos and other files to the **Amazon-based cloud**.

Amazon offers its **services** all over the world. It **operates** its own websites in the UK, Germany, China, Australia, as well as many South American and Asian countries.

Amazon.com was **founded** by Jeff Bezos in 1994. It first **operated** out of a small garage in Washington state. Within a year Amazon offered hundreds of thousands of books. People could not only order books from an online catalogue but also write their own **reviews**. In 1997 Amazon.com started trading **shares** on the NASDAQ **stock exchange**. By 2000 it made over a **billion** dollars in **sales**.

As time went on Amazon.com grew **gradually**. It bought many of its **rivals** and today **cooperates** with other companies and lets them sell their products via the Amazon website.

In 2007 Amazon went a step further. It surprised the electronics world with a **revolutionary** eBook reader, the *Kindle*, which today **dominates** the market. In 2011 a tablet computer followed, the *Amazon Fire*. In the following years the company started selling music downloads and **videos on demand**. Amazon **customers** can **store** everything they buy on their private cloud and download it anytime they want.

Today, Amazon.com **serves** 20 million **customers** every day. Its **annual income** is over 34 billion dollars.

There are a number of reasons for Amazon's success. One of them is company **founder** Jeff Bezos himself. *TIME* magazine's "*Man of the Year*" of 1999 is a **visionary**, an **ambitious** businessman who is not afraid of taking risks, even if it means a **downturn** for the company at first. Amazon's website tries to **personalize** the buying **experience** for its customers. It knows what you want and what you are interested in.

Although Amazon.com is the biggest internet **retailer** in the world it is often criticized. Economic experts say that Amazon is turning Internet business into a **monopoly**. Others **point out** the bad working **conditions** for Amazon **employees**.

Amazon is a business **empire** that sells almost anything cheaper and faster than anyone else.

Words

- **although** = while
- **Amazon-based** = here: something that only works with Amazon and its own computers
- **ambitious** = hard-working, very motivated
- **annual** = yearly

- **appliance** = machine that you use for doing something at home
- **billion** = a thousand million
- **cloud** = when you work on your own computer but use software or store files on other computers on the Internet
- **condition** = situation
- **cooperate** = work together with
- **customer** = a person who buys a product
- **dominate** = control, lead
- **downturn** = here: sales go down
- **empire** = here: very large company or group of companies
- **employee** = worker
- **experience** = event, something that happens
- **found – founded** = start something new
- **gradually** = slowly
- **income** = the money you get from selling products
- **monopoly** = a large company that controls all or most of the business
- **operate** = work
- **personalize** = to organize something so that it fits the habits of a certain person
- **point out** = want to show
- **retailer** = person that sells products to customers
- **review** = an opinion about a book, movie etc...
- **revolutionary** = something new or not done before
- **rival** = other company that wants to sell the same products
- **sales** = selling products
- **serve** = sell products to
- **services** = what a company offers its customers
- **share** = part of a company
- **sportswear** = clothes you need for doing sports
- **stock exchange** = a place where you can buy and sell parts of a company
- **store** = save something in order to use it later
- **tablet** = small computer with a touch screen, but without a keyboard and mouse
- **video on demand** = you can download a video to watch on your computer or TV whenever you want to
- **visionary** = someone who has clear ideas and strong feelings about the future

SWISS BANKS

Switzerland is not only well-known for chocolate and its watch-making industry. It is also famous for its **unique** banking and financial system. Banks play an important role in Switzerland's **economy**. Swiss banks have been **considered** to be the most **secretive** in the world for many **centuries**. About a third of all money held outside a person's home country - hundreds of **billions** of dollars - is **deposited** in Swiss banks.

Banking in Switzerland goes back to the 18th **century**. In the past, not only rich people but also **authoritarian regimes** and dictators have **secured** their money in Swiss banks. **Foreigners** who live in **unstable** and **troubled** areas also tend to keep money in secure Swiss banks instead of their own. During World War II German Nazis **deposited** much of the country's **wealth**, **especially** money and gold taken away from **Jews**, in Switzerland.

Switzerland has two large banks - UBS and Credit Suisse. Private banking also has a century-long tradition in the **alpine** country. **Currently**, about 130000 people work in the banking sector. **Major** banks have **overseas branches** that **employ** thousands. Switzerland's **popularity** as a safe bank **haven** has many reasons. For one, the country has a very stable and **prosperous** economy, and one of the highest **per capita incomes** in the world. It has been **neutral** for many centuries, **especially** during the two world wars. **In addition**, the Swiss franc is one of the most stable **currencies** in the world.

Swiss banks have to follow very **strict privacy** rules. In 1934, a **law** was passed that **forbade** Swiss banks to **reveal** the name of **account holders**. Banks **protect** the privacy of their clients in a way no other country in the world does. If a Swiss banker **reveals** anything about a person's bank account without **permission** he **commits** a criminal **act**. Such **regulations** have made Switzerland a **popular destination** for foreigners who do not want to pay **taxes** in their own country.

Lately, **however**, the Swiss government has been under constant pressure by other countries to change their bank laws, making it possible to **reveal** the names of possible drug dealers or international criminals. EU **officials claim** that more and more citizens are moving their money to Switzerland to **escape** taxation in their home country. Income that is not reported to the government is often deposited in Swiss banks.

In the past decade Swiss bank officials have been working together with international financial experts to **combat money laundering**. Under new laws they must report any financial **transactions** that look **suspicious**.

Words

- **account holder** = person who has money in a bank
- **act** = action
- **alpine** = in the Alps
- **authoritarian regime** = government that is very strict to its people and does not allow them basic rights or freedom
- **branch** = part of a company that does work in another country
- **combat** = fight

- **commit** = do something wrong or illegal
- **considered to be** = people think that ...
- **currency** = the money a country uses
- **currently** = at the moment
- **deposit** = put, place, leave
- **destination** = target
- **economy** = the system by which a country's money and goods are produced and used
- **employ** = give work to
- **escape** = get away from
- **especially** = above all
- **forbid** – forbade = not allow
- **foreigner** = person who lives in another country
- **haven** = place where you can put something in order to protect it from danger
- **in addition** = also
- **Jew** = someone, whose religion is Judaism
- **law** = rules that a country passes
- **major** = very important
- **money laundering** = when money that is received illegally is put into businesses and banks in other countries, so that it is difficult for people to find out where it came from
- **neutral** = not taking part in wars or helping other countries
- **official** = person in a high position in the government or other organisations
- **overseas** = countries across the ocean
- **per capita income** = the money every Swiss person earns in a year
- **permission** = being allowed to do something
- **popularity** = something that makes a place very attractive
- **privacy** = about private things
- **prosperous** = wealthy, booming
- **regulations** = rules
- **reveal** = make known
- **secretive** = private, guarded, well-defended
- **secure** = to make something safe
- **suspicious** = something that might be against the law
- **transaction** = here: when money is transferred from one account to another
- **troubled** = with many problems
- **unique** = only one of its kind; very special
- **unstable** = here: areas where the political situation can change very often

OPEC – THE WORLD'S OIL CARTEL

OPEC is the Organization of **Petroleum** Exporting Countries. It was **founded** in Bagdad in 1960 and has **currently** 11 members. OPEC's **aim** is to **regulate** the **amount** of oil that member nations produce and to keep prices at a **steady rate**. The countries get together **twice** a year and **agree on** how much oil each country is allowed to produce. OPEC's **headquarters** are in Vienna, the **capital** of Austria.

Before OPEC was created, there were large oil companies that controlled the world's oil production. They wanted to sell as much oil as possible and did not let **governments influence** their **decisions**. Oil-rich countries, **especially** in the Middle East, wanted more control over the oil that they produce. **As a result**, Iran, Iraq, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait and Venezuela **founded** OPEC. In the following years Qatar, Indonesia, Libya, Algeria, Nigeria, Ecuador, Angola and the United Arab Emirates also become members.

In the 1960s, OPEC did not have much power. This changed in 1973 when the third Arab-Israeli war started. The United States and a few European countries **supported** Israel. As a form of **punishment**, OPEC nations, **influenced** by the Arab countries, stopped selling oil to the West. Within the next six years oil prices **rose** to ten times the price of the early 1970s. OPEC countries became rich with so-called **petrodollars**; the West sank into deep **recession** because they needed OPEC's oil.

In the **aftermath** of the energy crisis of the 1970s, western countries started looking for **alternative** forms of energy in order to become more **independent** from OPEC and the oil-producing nations. In 1986, oil prices **dropped** to the lowest **rate** in history. Oil-producing nations lost much of their **income**. In the 80s and 90s OPEC's power **diminished**, often because of conflicts and **internal arguments** and because member states could not agree on **production quotas**. Some OPEC countries did not keep **agreements** and produced more oil, **thus** lowering prices.

After 2000, oil prices began to **rise** again and reached an **all-time high** in 2007. The financial crisis of 2007 and 2008 hit world **economy** hard and oil prices fell once again. Since the Arab Spring of 2011, prices have gone up and down **several** times.

Today OPEC still controls about 60% of the world's oil **reserves** and produces 40% of the world's oil. Saudi Arabia is the most powerful member of the group, because it has the largest reserves. **Even though** there have been **quarrels** in the **cartel** in the last 5 decades it **remains** a powerful organization.

Words

- **aftermath** = what comes after a special event
- **agree on** = decide, come to a decision
- **agreement** = promise, deal
- **aim** = goal; what somebody wants to do
- **all-time high** = the highest price in history
- **alternative** = other, new
- **amount** = how much of a product



- **argument** = quarrel, fight
- **as a result** = that is why
- **capital** = most important city of a country; in which the government is
- **cartel** = countries that agree to sell something at the same price
- **currently** = right now, at the moment
- **decision** = deciding something
- **diminish** = become less, weaker
- **drop** = go down
- **economy** = the system by which a country's money and goods are produced and used
- **especially** = above all
- **even though** = while
- **found-founded** = start, create something new
- **government** = people who rule a country
- **headquarters** = the main building of an organization
- **income** = the money you get for selling products
- **independent** = free
- **influence** = power, control
- **internal** = between member countries
- **petrodollars** = money that you get by selling oil
- **petroleum** = oil
- **production quota** = official limit on how much a country can produce
- **punishment** = penalty; to make someone suffer because they have done something wrong
- **quarrel** = argument, fight
- **rate** = here: price
- **recession** = difficult time in business, when there is less production and people do not earn enough money and buy things
- **regulate** = control
- **remain** = stay
- **reserves** = here: the oil that probably is in the ground and can be produced in the future
- **rise - rose- risen** = go up
- **several** = a few
- **steady rate** = stable price
- **support** = help; assist
- **thus** = therefore
- **twice** = two times



BANKS AND BANKING

A bank is a company that works with the money that the people give it. If you give your money to a bank, it not only **protects** it but pays you **interest** so that it can work with the money. This is one of the reasons why people save their money in a bank. Money may also be safer there than at home.

Banks also lend money to other businesses and **customers**. They collect extra money called banking **fees** with which they pay interest to savers as well as **salaries** for their workers. Banks make a **profit** because they collect more interest than they pay to savers.

Without banks the world's **economy** would not be able to grow. **Investors** would not find the money they need for new projects. Industries could not buy new machines and modern **technology**.

What kind of services do banks offer?

Banks **provide** their customers with a number of **services**. With a checking account you can pay your bills. A check is a slip of paper that tells the bank how much money it should **withdraw** from your **account** and pay to someone else. Today, more and more people use the internet, also a banking service, to pay their **bills**. Banks also give their customers plastic cards with which they can get money from their account everywhere and whenever they want. They can also use them to pay without cash at shops, gas stations and other stores. Checking accounts are a **comfortable** way for customers to **handle** their money.

For people who want to save money banks **offer** savings accounts. Usually, banks pay more interest for savings accounts than they do for checking accounts. They hope that the customers will leave their money in the bank for a long time, which is why the bank can work with this money and **offer** it as **loans**. Banks, **however**, cannot give all of their money as loans. In most countries the government **limits** the **amount** of money that banks can use as loans. They must always keep back a **certain percentage** in the form of **cash**.

People who need money for certain things like buying a house or a car need a lot of money quickly. The money they borrow from a bank is called a loan. In most cases they do not pay back all of the money at once but a small part of it, with **interest**, every month. If someone cannot pay back a loan the bank usually can take away **valuable** objects like cars or houses.

Modern banks offer their customers many other services as well. They tell them how they can make money with investments in **stocks** and **bonds**. **Credit cards** are given to customers as a **cash-free** way of buying things. Almost all banks have **automatic teller machines** (ATM) at which customers receive money from their account. Telephone banking is an easy way to pay your bills by calling a special telephone number and typing in a certain **sequence** of **digits**. Some banks even **deal** with **insurance**.

Types of banks

Commercial banks are the most important banks. They **offer** many services, different forms of **accounts** and also loans. While, at first, commercial banks only offered its services to **businesses** and companies, they are for everyone today.

Investment banks do not take or keep the money of **individuals**. They help organizations and large companies **raise** money on the international financial markets.

Central banks manage the banking system in a country. The Federal Reserve in the United States and Bank of England are two **prominent** banks that take over these **tasks**. The European Central Bank is **responsible** for the **circulation** of money in the Euro zone.

Online banks can often give their customers more interest because they do not have the **expenses** that **physical** banks do. They can be **accessed** over the internet and are becoming more and more popular.

Savings and loans are banks that specialize in financing houses. **Although interest rates** are higher such banks offer up to 30-year **mortgages**. Customers pay back their loan through a monthly **payment** that they can **afford**.

Development banks are financial organizations that help Third World Countries. They not only **provide** money for nations in Africa, Asia and South America, but also send **aid** workers and offer technical help.

International banking

The world's largest banks are **located** in Europe, the United States and Japan. In most cases they operate in many countries of the world. Because banking is a **global** industry that does not stop at a country's **borders** there must be worldwide **agreements**. International **standards** that banks must **obey** are written down in the Basel **accords**.

History of banking

Banking has a long tradition. In Mesopotamia bankers kept gold and silver for people and lent it to others. **Ancient** Rome and Greece had **similar** banking systems to the ones we have today.

During the Middle Ages Italy was the centre of European banking. **Jewish traders emerged** as the first bankers and became very successful businessmen. Florence and Venice became known as two cities in which many people earned their money through banking. The Medici family **dominated** Florence for over two centuries and **set up** Europe's largest bank in the 15 th **century**.

The first world wide banking crisis **emerged** during the **Great Depression** in 1929. Many **citizens** lost their jobs and their savings as banks **crashed**. In 1933 American president Franklin D. Roosevelt **signed** a **bill** in which the government **guaranteed** the savings of **depositors** if a bank went **bankrupt**.

In 2008 a banking crisis hit America and **spread throughout** the world. Banks gave homeowners **mortgages** without checking their financial backgrounds. House prices began to drop and banks lost a lot of money. Governments in many countries had to give them money and **prevent** them from becoming bankrupt.

Words

- **access** = the right to use something
- **accords** = set of agreements or rules
- **account** = the place where your money is kept
- **afford** = to have enough money for something
- **agreement** = written promise made by two or more people, companies or countries



- **aid** = help
- **amount** = sum
- **automatic teller machine** = a machine outside a bank that you use to get money from your account
- **bankrupt** = to go out of business
- **bill** = a written piece of paper that shows how much you must pay for something
- **bill** = a written suggestion for a new law
- **bond** = a document that shows a company or the government will pay back money that it has borrowed from you
- **border** = official line that separates two countries
- **business** = company
- **cash** = banknotes
- **cash-free** = without money
- **certain** = special
- **circulation** = movement, flow
- **citizen** = a person who lives in a country and has rights there
- **comfortable** = handy, practical
- **crash** = here: if you do not have enough money to pay what you owe someone
- **credit card** = a small plastic card that lets you buy things and pay for them later
- **customer** = a person who buys things
- **deal with** = work with, offer
- **depositor** = someone who puts money in a bank
- **digit** = number
- **dominate** = to be number one
- **economy** = a system of buying and selling goods in a country
- **emerge** = come up
- **expense** = the amount of money that you spend on something
- **fee** = charge, amount of money
- **global** = worldwide
- **Great Depression** = economic problems after the Wall Street crash of 1929; many banks and businesses went out of business and millions of people all over the world lost their jobs
- **guarantee** = promise
- **handle** = deal with
- **however** = but
- **individual** = single person

- **insurance** = the money you pay regularly to a company; it pays for a damage if something bad happens or if you become ill
- **interest** = the extra money that you must pay back when you borrow money
- **interest rate** = the percentage amount that banks give to savers when they leave their money there or charge customers when they borrow money
- **investor** = a person who gives money to a company or a business and wants to make a profit
- **Jewish** = someone whose religion is Judaism
- **limit** = to stop something from becoming higher or bigger
- **loan** = the amount of money that you borrow from a bank
- **located** = situated, to be found
- **mortgage** = agreement between a customer and a bank in which it lends you money to buy a house; you have to pay back the money with interest over a longer period of time
- **obey** = follow
- **payment** = monthly sum
- **percentage** = part of a whole
- **physical** = here: bank in a building that you can go to
- **profit** = income, extra money
- **prominent** = famous
- **protect** = look after, care for
- **provide** = give, offer
- **raise** = collect, gather
- **responsible** = in charge of
- **salary** = the money you get every month for doing your job
- **sequence** = series
- **service** = help or other types of work that you offer a customer
- **sign** = to put your name on a document
- **similar** = almost the same
- **spread** = to move from one place to another
- **standard** = guideline, rule
- **stock** = a share of a company
- **task** = job
- **technology** = machines, know-how
- **throughout** = all over
- **trader** = a person who buys and sells something
- **valuable** = very expensive, costly
- **withdraw** = take out



CREDIT RATING AGENCIES

A credit rating agency is a powerful company that **rates** how good you are in paying back your **debts**. It rates **businesses**, private **individuals** and even whole countries. The credit rating company gives a **score** on how **able** you are to pay back a **debt** or a **loan**.

Banks take risks when they **lend** person money. If they don't know anything about the person or company they lend money which they may not see ever again. The same **applies** to a whole country. If a country is in money troubles and it goes to banks to **seek loans** the banks must be sure that they can pay them back.

In the last few months and years problems on the European **financial** market have **arisen** because credit rating agencies have **downgraded** countries like Greece, Portugal or Ireland, making it more difficult for them to **borrow** money.

The rating of a credit rating agency has an **influence** on how much **interest** you must pay for a **loan**. **Individuals**, companies or countries with very good ratings usually get money at lower **interest rates**, whereas having a bad rating means that giving you money is a risky **business** so you have to pay more **interest**.

Although there are many credit rating agencies all over the world, three big ones that have the most power and **influence**: Standard & Poor's and Moody's, two **American-based agencies** control about 40 % of the market each. The third agency, Fitch ratings, controls about 14% and **operates** from New York and London.

Credit rating agencies collect all kinds of information on firms, companies and countries. The agencies get paid by the companies or businesses that want their **bonds** or **shares** rated.

Agencies have different **methods** of rating. The best possible rating is AAA, or triple A. This means that you can borrow money **cheaply**. Ratings can go all the way down to C or D, meaning that companies or businesses are not able to pay back money and are basically **bankrupt**.

In most cases credit rating firms also **assess** how businesses, regions and countries will **develop economically** in the future. For example, The United State's rating was **downgraded** by Standard and Poor's a short time ago to AA+ , because the agency thought there was a **slight** risk of borrowing money from the American government. Such a downgrading can cause the **loss** of a good **reputation** of a country or business.

Criticism of these credit rating agencies has come up in the past months and years. During the **global financial crisis** of 2008, the agencies **admitted** that they did make mistakes in their ratings, which led partly to the crisis. The rating agencies gave best ratings to borrowers during the housing crisis in America. It turned out that many were not able to pay their **debts** back.

Discussion has been going on about the **importance** of rating agencies. Some financial experts **doubt** that they are needed at all. European **politicians** criticize the fact that they are **dependent** on American rating agencies.

Words

- **able** = to be in a situation where you can do something
- **admit** = to say that something is true, even if you don't want it to be
- **American-based** = they have their command centre in America
- **apply** = work for
- **assess** = measure, find out
- **bankrupt** = without enough money to pay back
- **bond** = an official document that promises that a government or company will pay back money that it has borrowed from you
- **borrow** = to get something and give it back after a certain time
- **business** = here: task, job
- **criticism** = to say what you think is bad about something
- **debt** = the money that you have borrowed from someone and must give back
- **dependent on** = need
- **doubt** = to think that something may not be true or if you do not trust something
- **downgrade** = to give a lower rating
- **economically** = about the economy
- **financial** = money
- **global financial crisis** = between 2007 and 2009 in which many banks around the world collapsed and had to be helped by governments
- **importance** = meaning, power
- **influence** = power, control
- **interest rate** = the extra money that you must pay to a bank when you borrow money from them; in percent
- **lend** = to let someone borrow money from you for a short time
- **loan** = the money that you have borrowed from a bank
- **loss** = to no longer have something
- **operate** = work
- **politician** = person who is in politics or works for the government
- **rate** = to give a number or a score, based on the quality of something
- **reputation** = name, status
- **score** = number, rating
- **seek** = want to have
- **share** = the part of a company
- **slight** = small

STOCKS AND THE STOCK MARKET

The stock exchange is a marketplace where **brokers** buy and sell **stocks** and **bonds** for other people. Many countries have one or more stock exchanges. Smaller stock exchanges often **handle** only **national stock**, whereas the big stock exchanges **handle** the stock of big international **corporations**.

Corporation

A **corporation** is a company that has the **right** to **issue stocks**. They are registered with the **government** and have **laws** that **protect** them and their **shareholders**.

Every **corporation** has a **board of directors** who make **decisions** for the company.

People who invest in a **corporation** usually have **limited liability**. If a **corporation** goes **bankrupt** investors only lose the money that they have invested.

Stocks and Bonds

A person who buys **stock** becomes one of the company's **owners**. They buy a **share** of a company. A **bond** is an **agreement** to lend money to a company for a certain period of time. Companies sell **stocks** and **bonds** to people because they need money and want to **expand**. Sometimes they want to build more factories or **develop** more products.

If a company makes **profits** it can use the earned money in a few ways. It may decide to invest more into the company and **expand**. Most of the time the **shareholders** of the company get a **dividend**, which is a part of the yearly profit. This **dividend** is not always the same and can change from year to year.

Most **corporations offer** two kinds of **stock**. Owners of common stock can go to the **annual** meetings of **stockholders**, **present** their own ideas there, ask questions about the company and have a right to vote for the **board of directors**.

Owners of preferred stock usually do not have **voting rights** or the right to **attend** stockholders' meetings. However, they get **dividends**.

A person who buys a bond is not buying **ownership** in a company but **lending** the company money. It **promises** to give back the money to the **bondholder** after a certain time, such as ten or twenty years. In return for the money, the companies pay **interest**. Not only companies but also governments can **issue bonds** if they need money.

People buy **stocks** and **bonds** because they hope that a **corporation** will earn money as it grows. As time goes on **shareholders** usually earn more money by **owning** stock than by saving their money in a bank or investing in other things.

Buying **stock** is also a risky **business**. If you buy a **share** of a certain company and it does well over the years the **value** of your **shares** will go up. You could sell them at a much higher price than when you bought them. Sometimes, however, things happen that make the **value** of certain **stocks** go down. If a company does badly or goes **bankrupt** the **value** of your **shares** goes down too and you actually lose money.

There are many reasons why the price of a company's **stock** rise or fall. For example if people are afraid that prices will go down, they may start selling their **shares**. If many people sell a large number of **stocks**, they can **actually** make prices go down. If this **continues** for a longer time it may lead to a crash. Prices of **stocks** fall so low that people don't want to buy them any more because they are afraid they won't get their money back.

Stock exchange

To buy stock most people go to a **broker**, a person who is member of a company that is allowed to buy and **trade bonds** and **stock**.

Let's say someone in California wants to buy 2000 **shares** of a company. He doesn't have to travel to the New York Stock Exchange. He calls a **stockbroker**, usually a member of a **brokerage house**, who gives him information on the company and tells him the price of the **stock**. When the investor tells him to buy, the **broker** sends the **order** to his firm's **trading desk** at the stock exchange which then **places** the order. The order is sent to **stock tickers throughout** the country that **constantly display** the **value** of stocks. Because buying and selling stocks is **concentrated** in one place you know the price of each stock at once.

Stocks are often **traded** under a **contract** called an **option**. It allows a person to buy or sell **stock** at a **certain** price within a **certain** time. If the **value rises** within that time and within the price set the stock is quickly sold again. The prices change throughout the day **depending** on how good or bad **trading** is. Small **orders** are usually **executed** automatically by computers. Large **orders** however are **traded** directly at the stock exchange.

Each year investors **trade billions** of **shares** worth hundreds of **billions** of dollars. But not all companies are **listed** on the stock market. You must be pretty big and have a lot of power. You must also show the stock exchange that you are in a good financial position and that your company is doing well. The world's biggest stock exchange in New York has about 30000 companies **listed**.

To see how well or badly stocks are doing most stock exchanges have an **index**. This is a number that shows the **average share prices** of the **major** companies. The most important **indices** are the Dow Jones (New York), FTSE (London), DAX (Frankfurt), Nikkei (Tokyo), Hang Seng (Hongkong)

Bulls and Bears

Bears are **cautious** animals that don't like to move fast. Bulls are animals that like to **charge** ahead. At the stock exchange bears are investors who believe that the price of **stock** will go down. A bull believes that the prices will go up. Likewise, a bear market is a period in which **stocks** usually fall in **value**, a bull market a time when they **rise**.

History of the stock exchange

The first European stock exchange was founded in Antwerp, Belgium in 1531. The first stock exchange in England was formed by a group of **brokers** in London in 1773. Until that time people usually went to coffee houses to buy and sell **stocks** because they found the **brokers** there.

In New York City **brokers** met under an old tree on Wall Street. They organized the New York stock exchange in 1792.

For many years only rich people bought and sold **stock**. It was not until World War I that more and more private investors started investing their money in **stocks**. There was a **huge rise** in **value** and investors made a lot of money

Stock market crash of 1929

The worst **crash** happened in the United States in October 1929. Over many days investors sold so many **stocks** that the whole market **collapsed**. This **affected** the **economy** not only in America but in Europe as well. Farmers could not sell their **crops**, factories couldn't sell their products, banks had to close and workers earned very **little** money. This lasted for almost ten years and became later known as the **Great Depression**.

World's biggest stock markets

Place	Market value in trillion dollars
New York Stock Exchange	21
NASDAQ (New York)	4.5
Tokyo	4.5
London	4
Shanghai	3
Hongkong	3
Toronto	2.2
Frankfurt	2
Bombay	1.5

Words

- **actually** = really
- **affect** = influence
- **agreement** = if two people, companies or countries promise to do something
- **annual** = yearly
- **attend** = go to
- **average** = usual, normal
- **bankrupt** = if you don't have enough money to pay back banks and the money you have borrowed from other people
- **billion** = one thousand million
- **board of directors** = group of people in accompany who make the important decisions
- **bond** = a document that promises that a company or the government will pay back money to you
- **bondholder** = a person who owns bonds
- **broker** = someone who buys and sells things like shares of a company to other people

- **brokerage house** = a company of brokers
- **business** = company
- **cautious** = careful
- **certain** = special
- **charge** = attack; move forward very quickly
- **collapse** = break down
- **concentrated** = here: happens
- **constantly** = the whole time
- **continue** = to go on
- **contract** = a written paper between two people or companies
- **corporation** = a very big company
- **crash** = here: the collapse of the whole system
- **crop** = a plant like wheat or corn that farmers grow for food
- **decision** = a choice you make after you discuss something
- **depend** = something is affected by something else
- **develop** = grow
- **dividend** = part of a company's yearly profit that is divided up among shareholders
- **economy** = the system of buying and selling of goods in a country
- **execute** = to do, carry out
- **expand** = grow
- **government** = people who rule a country
- **Great Depression** = the time after the stock market crash; the 1930s in which people lost jobs in the US and in most European countries
- **handle** = deal with
- **huge** = very big
- **index, indices** = list of prices at the stock exchange
- **interest** = the extra money that you must pay back when you borrow something
- **issue** = the right to produce shares
- **lay** = system of rules that a country has
- **lend** = to give for a short time
- **limited liability** = you only pay a certain amount if something happens to you or your company – you don't have to pay all of it
- **list** = here: to be in a directory
- **little** = not very much
- **major** = important
- **national stock** = shares of a company that is in your own country

- **option** = the right to buy shares at a special price with in a certain time
- **order** =if someone asks you to buy or sell something
- **own** =have, possess
- **owner** = a person who something belongs to
- **ownership** =if you have or possess something
- **present** =show
- **profit** = the money you get when you sell things, after you have paid for your costs
- **promise** = to say that you will do something
- **protect** =defend, guard
- **right** =something that you are officially allowed to have or do
- **rise** = to go up
- **share** = a part of the ownership of a company
- **shareholder** = a person who owns shares of a company
- **stock** = a share or part of a company
- **stock exchange** = place where you trade stocks and bonds
- **stock ticker** = a special machine that prints the price of company stocks
- **stockbroker** = a person who buys and trades stock and bonds for other people
- **throughout** = in all of
- **trade** = to buy and sell goods
- **trading desk** = the place at the stock exchange where the trading takes place
- **value** = what something is worth
- **voting right** = the right to vote
- **whereas** =while, but

GLOBALIZATION

Your shirt was made in Mexico and your shoes in China. Your CD player comes from Japan. You can travel to Moscow and eat a Big Mac there and you can watch an American film in Rome. Today **goods** are made and sold all over the world, thanks to globalization.

Globalization lets countries move closer to each other. People, companies and organizations in different countries can live and work together. We can exchange goods, money and ideas faster and cheaper than ever before. Modern communication and technology, like the Internet, **cell phones** or satellite TV help us in our daily lives.

Globalization is growing quickly. A German company can **produce cars** in Argentina and then sell them in the United States. A businessman in Great Britain can buy a part of a company in Indonesia on one day and sell parts of another **business** in China the next, thanks to globalization. Fast food companies open shops around the world almost every day.

History of Globalization

Globalization is not new. For thousands of years people have been **trading** goods and travelling across great **distances**. During the Middle Ages, **merchants** travelled along the **Silk Road**, which **connected** Europe and China.

The modern **age** of globalization started with the Industrial Revolution at the end of the 18th century. New machines were able to produce cheaper **goods**. Trains and **steam-powered** boats transported products **farther** and faster.

Since 1980, globalization has been moving at a faster **pace**. Today it is easier for companies to work in other countries. The Internet gives them the chance of **reaching** more **customers** around the world. **Teleworkers** work for firms that may be far away.

However, there is a growing **debate** over globalization. **Governments** are **in favour** of globalization because the **economy** can grow. Other people are not so sure that there are only **advantages**. Here are some **arguments** from both sides:

Good sides

- Globalization lets countries do what they can do best. If, for example, you buy cheap **steel** from another country you don't have to make your own **steel**. You can **focus on** computers or other things.
- Globalization gives you a larger market. You can sell more **goods** and make more money. You can **create** more jobs.
- Consumers also profit from globalization. Products become cheaper and you can get new **goods** more quickly.

Bad sides

- Globalization **causes unemployment** in industrialized countries because **firms** move their **factories** to places where they can get cheaper workers.
- Globalization may **lead** to more **environmental** problems. A company may want to build **factories** in other countries because **environmental laws** are not as **strict** as

they are at home. Poor countries in the Third World may have to cut down more trees so that they can sell wood to richer countries.

- Globalization can **lead** to financial problems . In the 1970s and 80s countries like Mexico, Thailand, Indonesia or Brazil got a lot of money from **investors** who hoped they could build up new **businesses** there. These new companies often didn't work, so they had to **close down** and investors **pulled out** their money.
- Some of the poorest countries in the world, **especially** in Africa, may get even poorer. Their population is not as **educated** as in **developed countries** and they don't have the new technology that we do.
- Human, animal and plant **diseases** can **spread** more quickly through globalization.

Many experts say that we need a different kind of globalization in our world today. There must be ways to **make sure** that all countries profit from the good sides of globalization. We should help poorer countries by giving them better education and showing them how new technology works.

Every year, **leaders** of the world's biggest industrial countries get together to discuss **economic** problems. This meeting is called the **G8 summit**. In the last few years groups against globalization have organized protest marches and demonstrations to **point out** that not everyone is happy with how the world's **economy** is **developing**.

Words

- **advantage** = the good side of something
- **age** = period of history
- **argument** = reasons
- **business** = company
- **cause** = lead to
- **cell phone** = a mobile telephone
- **close down** = to stop producing goods
- **connect** = to link together
- **create** = make
- **customer** = a person who buys something
- **debate** = discussion
- **develop** = grow
- **developed countries** = rich , industrialized countries
- **disease** = illness
- **distance** = space
- **economic** = about the economy
- **economy** = the system of producing goods and products in a country and selling them
- **educated** = if you have gone to school and learned a lot
- **environmental** = everything that is about the air, water or land around us

- **especially** =above all, more than others
- **exchange** = to give someone something and get something else in return
- **factory** = building in which you produce goods
- **farther** =here: over greater distances
- **firm** = company
- **focus on** = concentrate on
- **G8** = Group of 8 = the most important industrialized countries in the world
- **goods** = things that you produce and sell
- **government** =the people who rule a country
- **however** =but
- **in favour of** = for something
- **investor** = a person who gives money to a company and expects to get more money in return
- **law** = rules that a country has
- **lead to** =cause
- **leader** = the most powerful person of a country
- **make sure** = to check that something has been done
- **merchant** = someone who buys and sells goods
- **pace** = speed
- **point out** = to show
- **produce** = make
- **pull out** = take out
- **reach** = get to
- **Silk Road** = an old route on which silk was carried from Europe to Central Asia
- **spread** =to move from one place to another
- **steam—powered** =run by a steam engine ; power is produced by making water hot so that it turns into a gas
- **steel** = a strong metal that you can form
- **strict** =exact
- **summit** = meeting for powerful leaders of a country
- **teleworker** = someone who works from home and uses a computer, telephone etc..
- **trade** = to buy and sell goods
- **unemployment** = if you don't have a job

CAPITALISM

Capitalism is an **economic** system in which private people, not the **government**, own and **run** companies. These companies **compete** with other companies for **business**. They decide what products they want to produce, how much they should cost and where to sell them. Companies do all these things in order to make **profits** for their **owners**. People who use their money to start companies or **run** companies are called capitalists.

Even though a **pure** form of capitalism does not exist and **governments** control the **economy** in some ways it **remains** the world's most popular economic system. In the United States the **government** keeps itself out of the **economy** as far as possible but in some European countries **economic** control is much larger. Other names for capitalism are free-market economy or free **enterprise**.

Features of capitalism

In a capitalist system **private households** need **goods**. They buy these **goods** from the **income** that they have. Some **households** have more **income** than others. Sometimes only one member of a **household** has a job, at other times both husband and wife go to work. Then they have more money to buy goods. This is the **demand** side of the **economy**.

On the other side companies and **businesses** offer **private households** goods and **services**. They produce the **goods** that they think **consumers** will want to buy. To do this they need workers to produce these **goods** and **services**. This is the **supply** side of the **economy**.

Companies and households get together at markets. Here they **exchange** goods, **services** and jobs (labour). A market is a place where people buy and sell things. In a capitalist **society** the prices of goods, **services** and **labour** are **determined** by **supply and demand**. If a lot of people want to buy a **certain** product its price will go up. Products that are mass produced usually have low prices.

Another important feature of capitalism is **competition**. Many companies may sell the same type of product. Companies will try to sell better products at a cheaper price so that they can get **consumers** to buy their products. Firms that cannot **compete** are very often **driven out** of business.

The same can be said about **wages**. In some cases businesses have to pay workers more money to get them to work. In other cases low paid work often exists in areas where there are more workers than are needed.

How governments regulate the economy

In today's world governments get **involved** in the **economy** in **certain** ways and leaders must often make **economic decisions**.

A government must make sure that there is enough **competition** to keep prices low the quality products high. If only a few companies produce products they may **agree** to keep prices high. In a **monopoly**, only one company produces **goods** and **services** that everybody needs, so it can set the price.

In the second half of the 19th century companies started to get bigger and bigger by **taking over** smaller ones. Soon these so-called **trusts** had a lot of power and controlled the

market and the prices. At the beginning of the 20th century the United States passed a **law** which helped smaller companies **survive**.

Business leaders often do not care about what their **decisions** may do to our **society**. For example, a factory may **pollute** a river by **pouring** dirty water into it. It is the job of government organizations to make sure that this does not happen.

The **state** of **economy** is not the same all the time. Normally, there are always ups and downs. Sometimes the **economy** of a country is in good **condition**, everybody has enough money and lots of goods are produced. On the other side there may be years in which there are a lot of **unemployed** people and **factories** cannot sell their products. The **business cycle** shows the **economy** in four phases.

Some **experts** believe that the government must **stabilize** and help the **economy** in bad times. It should lower **taxes** and **interest rates** so that people can borrow money more easily.

In capitalist countries some are very rich and can **afford** to buy everything. Others have little money and need clothing, food and a place to live. Many European countries have systems in which poor people are helped by the **government** and richer people have to pay more **taxes** etc. This system is called **social market economy**.

History of capitalism

Capitalism has **existed** since **ancient** times. But it became important in the 15th and 16th centuries with the **growth** of **trade**, industry and **banking**. Until the 1700s governments **encouraged** their **population** to make more money by selling goods to other countries. Imported goods were made more expensive so that countries could sell their own products. This became known as mercantilism.

The Industrial Revolution brought changes to the **economies** of many countries. Factory **owners** did not want governments to control **trade** any more. They wanted to **run** their companies by themselves. This idea became known as *laissez-faire*, which means "allow to do" in French. In his book, *The Wealth of Nations*, British **economist** Adam Smith **described** how *laissez faire* should. Great Britain became the first country to change its **laws** and allow **free trade**.

During this period countries produced more and more products and goods and many capitalists became rich. However, normal workers did not **earn** very much and had to work up to 16 hours a day, sometimes in dangerous places. These problems led to the **creation** of **trade unions**, which **protected** workers.

In the middle of the 19th century socialism became **popular**. The German Karl Marx **suggested** that the government should **take over** and control the **economy**. It should **own** all the land, the factories and companies. In a socialist **economy** the government tries to **spread** money **evenly** among the workers. Many countries followed these socialist ideas, which later on **led** to Communism.

Capitalism almost **collapsed** during the Great Depression of the 1930s. Many banks, factories and stores had to close and millions of people lost their jobs. Many did not believe in capitalism any more. As a result the British economist John Maynard Keynes **argued** that the **government** had to do something to fight **depression**. In America Franklin D. Roosevelt introduced a program called New Deal in which he gave Americans help that they needed in bad times.

Today Keynes' theory is widely **accepted** and modern countries **combine** capitalism with some kind of government control. The **state** may own industries that are important to the country's **economy**, like **oil wells**, banks or airlines. Most people feel that free market economy should **remain** but the **government** should still be around to see that **economic rules** are kept.

Words

- **afford** = if you have enough money that you can buy the things you need
- **agree** = if two or more people have the same opinion about something
- **argue** = to say things that others don't think are right
- **business** = company
- **business cycle** = the ups and downs of the economy over a certain time
- **collapse** = break down
- **combine** = mix
- **compete** = to try to get people to buy your goods and not the ones from other companies
- **condition** = same as "state"
- **consumer** = someone who buys and uses products and services
- **creation** = the making of
- **decision** = what someone chooses to do or decides
- **demand** = the need to have certain things
- **depression** = when an economy almost breaks down completely
- **determine** = here: control
- **drive out of business** = if you have to stop producing things because you cannot compete with others
- **earn** = to get money for the work you have done
- **economic** = financial
- **economist** = a person who knows a lot about how business works
- **economy** = the system of producing goods and selling them
- **encourage** = to tell someone they should do something that is good
- **evenly** = to give everyone the same
- **exchange** = to give and get things
- **exist** = to be here
- **expert** = person who knows a lot about something
- **factory** = building where you produce goods
- **feature** = the main ideas of
- **free enterprise** = to allow companies and business to operate without much control

- **free trade** = if you can buy and sell things freely in your country and in other countries
- **goods** = things that are produced so that you can sell them
- **Great Depression** = the bad times that followed the stock market crash in 1929
- **growth** = development
- **income** = the money you get when you have a job and work
- **interest rate** = the percentage that you have to give a bank when you get money from it or the money that you get from the bank when you keep money there
- **involve** = to get mixed up in ; to be a part of
- **labour** = work
- **law** = the set of rules a country has
- **lead to** = to make something happen
- **monopoly** = if one company, government or person controls everything
- **offer** = to give people the things that they want
- **oil wells** = large structures you use to pump oil out of the earth
- **own** = to have something that belongs to you
- **pollute** = to make dirty
- **pour** = to make water flow into it
- **private household** = people who live privately in one house
- **profit** = the money you get from selling things after you have paid your costs
- **pure** = unmixed, real
- **run** = to be in charge of , to control
- **services** = work that you do for a person or an organization
- **social market economy** = economy in which the government takes more money away from richer people and helps poorer ones
- **society** = people, the general public
- **spread** = give
- **stabilize** = here: to stop the economy from getting worse
- **supply** = amount of goods that can be sold
- **supply and demand** = difference between the amount of goods that are produced and the amount that people want to buy
- **take over** = to take control of something or buy a company
- **trade** = to buy and sell things
- **trade union** = organization that helps workers and defends them against company owners
- **trust** = here: a group of companies that work together so that smaller companies cannot compete with them
- **wage** = money you earn in a week or month



MONEY

Money is something that is very difficult to **explain**. People in **various** cultures think of money in different ways. A London banker and an African **tribesman** have different ideas of what money is.

Many people think of money as a **currency** –metal **coins** and paper **bills**. We need it to buy the things in life that we need. We also get money for the work that we do. So, money is a way of exchanging goods and services.

The History of Money

In early **civilisations** people did not have money. They **traded** objects. Maybe a hunter had more animal **furs** than he could use and his neighbour might have caught more fish than he could eat himself. They soon saw that they needed each other. The fisherman needed **furs** to **protect** himself from the cold and the hunter needed something to eat, so they **exchanged** their **goods**. This is called **barter**.

Barter also had **disadvantages**. If there weren't any more people who needed the hunter's **furs** he couldn't **trade** them for the things he needed.

Early Forms of Money

As time went on, people used things that were **valuable** as a kind of money. **Cattle** was one of the earliest forms of money. People who had many cows were **thought to be** very rich. Later on, **grain** and salt were **common** forms of money. They had **advantages** because you could **weigh** them.

The Aztecs used cacao beans as money. They were **valuable** and easy to carry. The early American colonists used **gunpowder**, tobacco and **nails** as money. These things were very **rare**.

Coins

In the **course of time** people searched for better ways of **trading** goods. They found out that metal, **especially** gold and silver, was very **valuable**.

Some historians believe that the first **coins** were made at around 700 B.C. by the **Lydians**. The Greeks and Romans also had silver and gold **coins**. Their **value** was **guaranteed** by the **government**.

But it was not until the late Middle Ages that **coins** became **common** throughout Europe. Metals were **stamped** and coins had to have a certain **weight**. People knew how many coins they needed to buy something because they had a **fixed value**.

Paper money

Paper money **came into use** about 300 years ago. The idea came from **goldsmiths** who gave people pieces of paper in **exchange** for their gold. These **bills** could be **exchanged** for their gold later on. They told you that **real** gold and silver existed somewhere.

Until the middle of the 20th **century governments** all over the world had **deposits** of gold that was worth as much as the money they gave to their people. Paper money had many **advantages**. It was cheaper to make and easier to carry around.

But there were also dangers. **Governments** could produce as much paper money as they wanted. If they produced too many banknotes and gave them to the people, they would

have too much money to spend. If there were not enough **goods** to buy, prices would go up. The money then would **lose** its **value**. We call this inflation.

Today, the **amount** of money in **circulation** is controlled by **central banks**. They make sure that paper money has a **constant value**.

In the second half of the 20th century people **realized** that they didn't have to carry money around to buy the things they needed. Information about money was sent from bank to bank, so you could have your money transferred from one place to another without **touching** it.

Credit cards

Today, more and more people use credit cards to buy things. You don't have to take **real** money with you. With a credit card the bank **lends** its **customer** money to buy something. The **customer signs** a small **slip** of paper and the shop assistant sends it to the bank and gets his money at once. A few weeks later the **customer** pays the money back to the bank.

The Euro

In 1991 the leaders of the European Union got together in Maastricht, the Netherlands and **agreed** on **creating** a **single currency** for all of Europe.

On January 1, 2002, the Euro became the **official** money in twelve of the fifteen EU nations. Only Great Britain, Sweden and Denmark wanted to stay with their old **currency**.

In 2004, ten central and eastern European nations **joined** the EU. They will **decide** later on if they want to **join** the Euro zone.

When banks and **stock exchanges** began using the Euro in 1999 it was worth 1.17 US dollars. Shortly **afterwards** it became weaker and fell to 0.80 US dollars, but since 2002 its **value** has **risen constantly**, almost up to 1.30 US dollars.

The colourful euro banknotes were **designed** by the Austrian Robert Kalina. They **range** from € 5 to € 500 and have a map, the EU flag, as well as **arches**, bridges and windows on them.

There are eight **coins** — **ranging** from 1 cent to 2 Euros. One side of the coins all look the same but on the other side each country has its own national **design**.

People **in favour** of introducing the Euro **argue** that the European **currency** will **increase trade** among European countries. It could also **unify** the union and make it stronger. Many **economic experts** also **predict** that the Euro can compete with the US dollar as an important international **currency**.

Words

- **advantage** = good side about something
- **afterward** = after
- **agree** = to say yes to something
- **amount** = quantity, sum
- **arch** = a building with a curved top and straight sides

- **argue** = here: to say
- **barter** = a system without money; you exchange goods for other goods
- **bill** = a piece of paper money
- **came into use** = to start to use
- **cattle** = cows
- **central bank** = a national bank that controls the money in a country
- **century** = a hundred years
- **circulation** = the money that all the people in a country have
- **civilisation** = culture
- **coin** = a round piece of metal that is used as money
- **common** = if a lot of people use something
- **constant** = always the same
- **course of time** = as time went on
- **create** = to make ; here : to introduce
- **currency** = the money that a country uses
- **customer** a person who goes to a shop and buys things
- **decide** = to choose
- **deposit** = a safe place where you put money or a lot of gold
- **disadvantage** = bad side of something
- **economic** = financial
- **especially** = above all
- **exchange** = trade; to give someone something for something else
- **explain** = to make clear; to put in simple words
- **fixed value** = always worth the same
- **fur** = the thick soft hair of an animal
- **goldsmith** = someone who makes or sells things made of gold
- **goods** = products
- **government** = the people who rule a country
- **grain** = seeds of corn, rice, wheat and other crops that are collected and used for food
- **guarantee** = to promise something
- **gunpowder** = material used to make bombs and fireworks
- **in favour** = to be for something
- **increase** = to go up
- **join** = to become a member of
- **lend** = to let someone borrow money from you
- **lose** = drop, go down

- **Lydians** = people who once lived in today's Turkey
- **nail** = a thin pointed piece of metal that you hit with a hammer
- **official** = something that is allowed in a country
- **predict** = to say that something will happen
- **protect** = defend, guard
- **range** = to go from ... to ...
- **rare** = not very often
- **real** = true
- **realise** = to find out
- **rise** = to go up
- **services** = The work that someone does for a person
- **sign** = to write your name on a document or an important piece of paper
- **single currency** = the money that many countries have
- **slip** = piece
- **stamp** = to put a sign on a coin
- **stock exchange** = place where stocks or parts of a company are bought and sold
- **the design** = motifs, pictures etc..
- **thought to be** = said to be
- **to design** = to make a drawing or plan of something
- **touch** = to feel with your hand
- **trade** = buying goods from and selling goods to other countries
- **tribesman** = a man who is member of a big family that is ruled by one leader
- **unify** = to bring together
- **valuable** = worth a lot of money
- **value** = what something is worth
- **various** = different
- **weigh** = how heavy something is



INTERNATIONAL TRADE

Trade is the buying and selling of goods and **services**. The products that are **exchanged** are things that people grow or make, like food to eat, machines to work with or clothes to wear. **Services** are things that people do for others, like working in bank, caring for old people or teaching pupils.

Why do we trade?

Trade happens because people need or want things that they don't have. We also trade for work that we cannot do ourselves. Trade between countries happens for the same reason. Some countries, for example, have natural **resources**, like coal, oil or wood which other countries might want to buy. They try to sell the goods, products or services that they have too much of to other countries. They earn money from these **sales** and then can buy the things that they themselves need and cannot produce **on their own**.

Both producers and **consumers** profit from international trade. If countries can produce **goods** more cheaply than others because they specialize on them why not let them. They make more money on one side and **consumers** in other countries can buy goods that are cheaper.

Even though many nations have a lot of different goods to export there are countries that **depend** only on one or two products to get money. Saudi Arabia, Kuwait and other countries of the Middle East **depend** on oil exports, because it is pretty much the only thing that they can sell. Poor countries in Africa **depend largely** on the export of tropical farm products to get money.

Each year goods and **services** worth about 11 **trillion** dollars (\$ 11 000 000 000 000) are traded all over the world. The biggest exporting nations are The United States, France, Germany, the United Kingdom, Canada and Japan.

The difference between what a country exports and what it imports is called the **balance of trade**. If a country exports more than it imports we call this a trade **surplus**. And if a country pays more for its imports than it gets for its exports it has a trade **deficit**.

How trade is limited

In some countries the government controls all trade and in others it allows companies and firms to trade freely. **However**, all governments control trade in some way.

Sometimes a government **forbids** companies to buy or sell dangerous or **illegal** products, or military technology. When companies **expand** and get bigger they often **take over** others and form a **monopoly**. Governments pass **laws** to **prevent** companies from becoming too strong and powerful and from controlling the market.

Many governments try to help their own industries by making it more difficult to import **foreign** products. They put import **taxes** on **foreign** goods to make products more expensive and their own products cheaper. A government may also **limit** the number of products that it will buy from another nation. European countries, for example, may **limit** the number of cars that are imported from Japan or the USA. They want their people to buy European cars. We call this strategy **protectionism** because governments want to **protect** their companies and industries.

History of trade

Trading is as old as **mankind**. The early civilizations of Mesopotamia or Egypt traded among themselves and with other people. **Gradually, trade routes developed** over land and sea. These were used to transport spices, salt, minerals and **jewels** over great **distances**.

In the 15 th **century** Europeans started **exploring** the seas to find new **trade routes** to Asia. The Portuguese **explored** the coast of Africa, the Spanish, English and French **set across** the Atlantic and **founded** colonies in the New World.

In the 1700s the Industrial Revolution began in Great Britain. During the following two **centuries** it became the most powerful trading nation in the world. The British sold goods to its colonies and **received** raw **materials** from them.

During this **era** governments did not **interfere** much with free trade. As a result many **owners** became very rich. They kept all the money themselves and paid workers badly. In the first half of the 20th century World War I and the Great Depression led to the **decline** of world trade. Many governments **introduced** new plans to help their own companies' workers.

After the Second World War the big countries of the free world tried to **improve** free trade. Some have formed **trading blocs** that trade freely. The biggest of them are the European Union, NAFTA and South America's Mercosur. About 150 countries are members of the World Trade Organization, an institution that **sets up rules** for world trade.

Words

- **balance of trade** = the difference in value between the goods that you buy and the goods that you sell
- **century** = a hundred years
- **consumer** = a person who buys something
- **decline** = to go down
- **deficit** = to have less than you need
- **depend on** = here: to need something very much
- **distance** = how far away something is
- **era** = time
- **even though** = while
- **exchange** = to give and get something in return
- **expand** = to get bigger
- **explore** = to travel around an area in order to find out something about it
- **forbid** = not allow
- **foreign** = from another country
- **found** = to setup, start
- **gradually** = slowly

- **Great Depression** = the economic problems that followed the Wall Street crash of 1929; it started in the USA and spread to Europe and the rest of the world; many banks and companies had to close down and people lost their jobs
- **however** = but
- **illegal** = against the law
- **improve** = to make better
- **interfere** = to get involved in
- **introduce** = to show for the first time
- **jewel** = a valuable stone or rock
- **largely** = very much
- **law** = the system of rules that a country has
- **limit** = control, regulate, reduce
- **mankind** = all the humans as a group
- **monopoly** = a large country that controls all the sales of a product
- **owner** = a person who has something
- **prevent** = to stop something from happening, not to let something happen
- **protectionism** = when a government tries to help its own industries by putting a tax on products that it imports
- **raw materials** = things that exist in nature and that people use, like wood, coal or oil
- **receive** = get
- **resources** = same as "*raw materials*"
- **rule** = an instruction that says how something must be done
- **sale** = when you sell something
- **services** = the work that someone does for another person or organization
- **set across** = here: sail across
- **set up** = make
- **spice** = a kind of powder that you take from plants; you put it into the food that you cook to give it a special taste
- **surplus** = to have more than you need
- **take over** = to control
- **tax** = money that the government collects from people and uses for services
- **trade route** = a way across land or sea used by traders in the past
- **trading bloc** = a group of countries that trade freely with each other
- **trillion** = a number with twelve zeros

THE THIRD MAN

Holly Martins, an American writer of bad cowboy stories arrived in Vienna one cold morning in February. It was shortly after World War II. Vienna was in **ruins** and **occupied** by the four Allied powers, the Americans, the Russians, the British and the French. Holly Martins had been invited to Vienna by an old friend, Harry Lime, and so he was surprised that Harry was not there to meet him. When Holly went to Harry's **flat** he found out that his friend had been hit and killed by a truck as he was crossing the street.

The **funeral** was taking place that afternoon so Holly went to the **cemetery**. There were very few people present. A beautiful dark-haired woman was the only one of them who looked worried. After the funeral, Major Calloway, a British military policeman, told Holly that his friend Harry had been a criminal **involved** in **illegal** business but Holly did not believe him. Back at his hotel, Holly met a man who **mistook** him for a famous American novelist and asked him to give a **lecture**. Holly **accepted**, because this would give him a chance to stay in Vienna for a few more days and find out what really happened to Harry.

The next day, Holly began his search. He first met an Austrian friend of Harry's called Kurtz. Kurtz described how he and another man, Popescu, had carried Harry's body to a **square** after the accident. Before he died, Harry had asked Kurtz to look after Holly and Anna. This surprised Holly because Calloway had told him that Harry's death had been very **sudden**. Holly asked Kurtz about the woman at the cemetery. She was Harry's girlfriend, Anna Schmidt, an actress.

That evening, Holly met Anna and she told him more about the accident. Harry's doctor, Dr Winkel, had been passing by and had **certified** his death. The driver of the truck had been Harry's own driver. In fact, there had been no strangers there at all. Holly began to think that it might not have been an accident at all. The porter of Harry's flat then gave Anna and Holly another version. Harry had died **immediately** and three men had carried the body. So who was this mysterious "third man" ?

When they got back to Anna's flat, Calloway was there and **arrested** Anna because her papers were **forged**. Holly told Calloway what he had learned about Harry's death but Calloway told him to "leave death to the professionals" and go home. However, Harry decided to find out the truth. He talked to Dr Winkel and Popescu, Harry's Romanian friend. Popescu denied that there had been a "third man" **involved** in the accident.

When Holly went back to the scene of the accident, the porter said, "I'd like to tell you something ... come to my place tonight". But when he and Anna went to see the **porter** that night, they found that he had been murdered. The porter's son **accused** Holly of being the murderer. Anna and Holly had to escape and after hiding in a cinema Holly finally got back to his hotel to find a taxi driver waiting to take him to his evening lecture.

Holly's lecture was so terrible that most people left before it was over, but Popescu stayed there. He asked Holly questions about his new novel. Holly said that it was a murder story; it was based on fact and called "*The Third Man*". After **escaping** from Popescu and two other men Holly went to **police headquarters**. Calloway told Holly in detail about Harry's crimes. He had sold **diluted penicillin** that had caused the deaths of thousands of **innocent victims**, **especially** children. Holly was finally **convinced** and decided to leave Vienna.

He went to say goodbye to Anna and suddenly saw a man standing in a door on the other side of the street. It was Harry Lime! He called out his name but Harry mysteriously **disappeared**. Holly rang Calloway and they found out that Harry had escaped underground into Vienna's **sewers**. Holly spoke to Kurtz and Winkel and told them to organize a meeting with Harry. The two friends met at last on the big wheel in the Prater **amusement park**. Harry showed no **regrets** for the crimes he had committed and even threatened to kill his old friend Holly. After that, Holly agreed to help Calloway catch Harry.

They decided to use Holly to set up a **trap**. She was supposed to meet Harry in a cafe which Calloway and his men had **surrounded**. Anna came in and tried to warn Harry but it was too late. Harry pulled out his gun to kill Holly but the police came in. Harry escaped and disappeared underground. Calloway, his men and Holly followed him into the **sewage system** of Vienna. Suddenly there were shots. **Cornered** like a rat and badly **wounded** Harry tried to go up a ladder and out of the sewer. Holly saw his friend and went after him. When Harry pulled the gun on his friend Holly shot him.

Before he left Vienna, Holly went to his friend's second **funeral**. There were even fewer people than at the first one. Afterwards, Holly tried to talk to Anna but she ignored him and walked away.

Words

- **accept** = to say yes
- **accuse** = to blame someone for doing something
- **amusement park** = large park with roller coasters, rides, merry-go-rounds and other attractions
- **arrest** = to take to a police station because the police think that a person has done something against the law
- **cemetery** = piece of land on which dead people are buried
- **certify** = to say that something is true
- **convinced** = sure, certain
- **corner** = to force a person into a situation from which they cannot escape
- **dilute** = to make thinner
- **disappear** = go away, not to be seen again
- **escape** = to get away from
- **especially** = above all
- **flat** = apartment
- **forge** = to illegally copy something
- **funeral** = to bury someone who has died
- **illegal** = against the law
- **immediately** = at once
- **innocent** = here: to get hurt even though you are not involved in something

- **involve** = take part in
- **lecture** = speech
- **mistake** = to wrongly think that you are a certain person, but you are not
- **occupy** = here: to be controlled by
- **penicillin** = type of medicine that is used to treat infections
- **police headquarters** = the main office of the police
- **porter** = here: someone whose job it is to look after a building
- **regret** = to be sorry
- **ruins** = to be completely destroyed
- **sewage system** , **sewer**= passage under the ground that carries away waste material and water from houses or factories
- **square** = larger area in a city
- **sudden** = without warning
- **surround** = to be all around
- **trap** = clever trick to catch someone
- **victim** = here: person who gets hurt or is killed
- **wounded** = hurt



AMUSEMENT PARKS

An amusement park is an outdoor **area** with games, rides and shows. They are **spread** over a large area, often many square kilometers. Young and old visitors can enjoy many types of **attractions**. They can ride on **roller coasters**, go high up in the air in a **Ferris wheel** or ride on **carousels**. Amusement parks also offer restaurants and bars to eat and drink, as well as green areas with grass to sit down or relax.

Most amusement parks have a **fixed** location. Some of them are open all year round, others only during the warmer season. Today amusement parks have been **replaced** by theme parks. These places **focus** on a **certain** topic of history or natural life. The first theme park, Disneyland, opened in California in 1955.

History

In the Middle Ages **minstrels** wandered around and sang in open areas. **Entertainers gathered** in a town field or a **market square**. After a few days they went to another town. They often **performed** in **tents** and offered food and entertainment. **In addition**, visitors could see circus artists **perform** or have their **portrait** painted by street painters.

The first real amusement parks **emerged** out of **fairs** and **public** gardens in Europe in the 16th century. Later on amusement parks in **fixed** locations **developed** in larger cities. The Prater in Vienna was the **basis** for many amusement parks in other **locations**. The first amusement park in the United States was **located** on Coney Island, in New York City. For a long time it was the world's biggest attraction, with bars, souvenir shops, rides along a long beach. After its **peak** in the 1920s, the amusement area's **popularity declined**.

After World War II **larger-scale** amusement parks started **developing** in Europe and other continents. Up to the end of the twentieth **century** European parks are small compared to their American **counterparts**. The first large amusement park outside the USA was Euro Disneyland, which opened in Paris in 1990. In Japan an Asian version of Disneyland opened in 1993. In Denmark, Legoland **features miniature** buildings and attractions built out of the world-famous Lego plastic **bricks**.

Rides and Attractions

Rides are the greatest **attractions** of amusement parks. By the 19th century many entertainment parks had carousels or **merry-go-rounds**. They began to become popular during **medieval tournaments** where **knights** fought against each other. Later on **roller coasters** were added to the attractions of amusement parks. They featured **steep drops** from high **altitudes**. Roller coasters **originated** from Russian ice **slides** that were built for the people as early as the 17th century.

Today almost every amusement park has a Ferris wheel. The first original Ferris wheel in the United States was built for the Chicago **Exhibition** in 1893. It allowed visitors to rise to about 80 meters. Today Ferris wheels are not only located in amusement parks but in other places as well. London Eye, for example, is **situated** on the Thames River and gives visitors a **breathtaking** view of London.

Other attractions of amusement parks **include** twistlers and **spin-based** machines that give visitors a **thrilling experience**. More and more amusement parks are **designing** new machines that give their visitors a new feeling. What would an amusement park be without **various** water rides, **especially** in the summer when it's hot? **Haunted** houses

show visitors a **variety** of mirrors which make them thinner or fatter and **cause optical illusions**.

Many amusement parks offer their visitors special trains that take them from one attraction to another. Special **safety features** are built into all of these attractions so that they cannot cause any damage, **although** accidents sometimes do happen. With the **advent of electricity** amusement parks opened at night and allowed people working during the daytime to go there too.

Words

- **advent** = coming, beginning
- **although** = while
- **altitude** = height
- **area** = place
- **attraction** = an interesting object to see or enjoy
- **basis** = starting point
- **brehtaking** = wonderful
- **brick** = a small block used as a toy
- **carousel** = machine with wooden horses on it that turns around and around, which people can ride in for fun
- **cause** = lead to
- **century** = a period of a hundred years
- **certain** = special
- **counterpart** = the same thing but only in a different place
- **decline** = to go down
- **design** = plan, make
- **develop** = grow
- **drop** = to go down to a lower place
- **electricity** = the power that is carried by cables and wires and give you light
- **emerge** = come from
- **entertainer** = a person who sings, tells jokes or dances in front of people
- **especially** = above all
- **exhibition** = fair, show
- **experience** = something that happens
- **fair** = large area with rides and other attractions
- **feature** = offer, present to the visitor
- **Ferris wheel** = a large wheel that has cabins which people can ride in
- **fixed** = not moving

- **focus** = center
- **gather** = get together
- **haunted** = scary, ghostly
- **in addition** = also
- **include** = consist of
- **knight** = a man who was trained to fight riding a horse
- **larger-scale** = bigger
- **location** = place
- **market square** = place in the middle of a town where products were traded
- **medieval** = in the Middle Ages
- **merry-go-round** = carousel
- **miniature** = very small
- **minstrel** = a singer or musician in the Middle Ages
- **optical illusion** = a picture or image that tricks your eyes and makes you see something that is not there
- **originate** = come from; start out from
- **peak** = when something is at its best
- **perform** = act in front of people
- **popularity** = when something is liked by many people
- **portrait** = drawing or painting of a person
- **public** = for everybody to visit
- **replace** = here: to build something else instead
- **roller coaster** = a track with steep slopes and curves; people ride in small cars at a very fast speed
- **safety feature** = something built in that protects you from danger
- **situated** = located
- **slide** = you can move down a flat surface
- **spin-based** = here to go round and round quickly
- **spread** = stretch, reach from one place to another
- **steep** = sharp
- **tent** = an object you can sleep in when you go camping; it is made up of cloth and poles
- **thrilling** = exciting
- **tournament** = fighting between soldiers and knights in the Middle Ages
- **variety** = selection
- **various** = different kinds of

THE SIMPSONS

The Simpsons is an American **sitcom** that shows middle class lifestyle in **cartoon** form. The half-hour **episodes** take place in and around the **fictional** town of Springfield and make fun out of American culture and **society**.

Since the show started in 1989 the Simpsons have been **broadcast** over 500 times. This makes it the longest running sitcom in American television history. In 2007 a **full-length** movie, *The Simpsons Movie*, made over half a **billion** dollars.

The Simpsons has won many prizes, concluding the **Emmy Awards**. In the year 2000 Time magazine named it the best television series of the **century** and the cartoon characters of *The Simpsons* **received** their own star on Hollywood's Walk of Fame.

The Simpson family **consists** of 5 **main** characters. Homer is the rather **clumsy**, beer-drinking father. He works at a **nuclear power plant** in Springfield and is married to Marge Simpson, a typical American middle class housewife. The couple has three children. Bart is a ten-year old who **constantly** gets into trouble. Lisa is a highly intelligent eight-year old who has become a vegetarian and a Buddhist. Maggie, the family's baby, is often shown with a **pacifier**. The Simpsons have two pets, a dog named *Santa's Little Helper* and *Snowball*, a cat.

Even though the series **focuses** around **animated** characters, many human **celebrities** have **starred** on *The Simpsons* in the past, for example, Bill Clinton, Tony Blair, Tom Jones or Mel Gibson.

The comedy centers on a few **major** themes. Homer's work in a nuclear power plant opens up the topic of our **environment** for discussion. Bart and Lisa are often shown in their school life where educational problems arise. Homer and Marge try to **raise** their children as best as they can but, as in many typical families, do not always **succeed**. The series also makes political comments and **criticizes** how the **government** and large **corporations exploit** the normal worker.

The program has been very **successful** around the world. It is watched by millions of people in over a hundred countries. *The Simpsons* have **triggered** a **merchandising** industry **revolving** around T-shirts, DVDs, video games, a **theme park** and books.

Words

- **animated** = made to look as if they are moving
- **billion** = a thousand million
- **broadcast** = to send out a radio or television program
- **cartoon** = film with drawings of characters
- **celebrity** = a famous person
- **century** = a hundred years
- **clumsy** = to do something in a very funny way
- **consist** = made up of
- **constantly** = always

- **corporation** = a very big company
- **criticize** = not approve of
- **Emmy Awards** = prize awarded for the best television shows
- **environment** = the world around us
- **episode** = one of a series of programs that is continued every day or every week
- **even though** = while
- **exploit** = to treat someone in an unfair way, or to do something that will give you profits
- **fictional** = not real; it does not exist
- **focus** = center
- **full-length** = the normal length of a movie
- **government** = the people who rule a country
- **main** = important
- **merchandising** = products that are about the topic
- **nuclear power plant** = building that uses produces electricity by splitting atoms
- **pacifier** = a small rubber that a baby puts into its mouth and sucks
- **raise** = educate; to help them grow up
- **receive** = get
- **revolve** = here: to center on
- **sitcom** = situation comedy; a funny television program with the same characters every week
- **star** = to be a part of a film
- **succeed** = to do something and get the best results
- **successful** = popular
- **theme park** = large park that focuses on a certain topic; people go there, enjoy themselves and have fun
- **trigger** = set off, start

THE NINTENDO WII

The *Wii* is a video game **created** by Nintendo that uses a **wireless controller** to show the **movements** of your body, hands and legs on a television screen. It was first presented to the **public** in November 2006

Wii controllers have many forms and **shapes**. For example, they can **simulate** the **movement** of a tennis racket, a golf club or other things. A fitness **pad** allows you to do **exercises** that a fitness trainer on the television screen shows you.

The *Wii* turns a video game into a physical **activity** that is fun too. It is also used by doctors and **therapists** who show **patients** how to **balance** themselves or build up muscles after an operation or illness.

But how does the *Wii* really work? There are chips, sensors and **accelometres** in the *Wii remote* that can **record shifts** and **angles** in your body movements. You can move it in all directions. When the body moves these changes are sent via **Bluetooth** to a console. You can shoot at something by pressing a button, move an object on the screen and do many other things with the remote.

There are many **advantages** of Nintendo's *Wii*. It is easy to use and the controller is fast and **accurate**. Objects move on the screen exactly the way you would expect them to.

In 2006 Nintendo **released** a new game console called *Wii Fit* **containing** more than forty different kinds of **physical** exercises. It has a wireless **balance board** that you can stand, sit or lie on. It can **calculate** your **body mass index** and be your personal fitness trainer. The balance board can also be used for other sports that **require** a **sense of balance**, like snowboarding or windsurfing.

With the *Wii* you cannot only compete with other players in your own living room. You can **connect** the console to the Internet and play with people around the world.

In the meantime you can buy many other **accessories** that work with the *Wii*. A **steering wheel** that gives you the feeling of driving a real car, boxing **gloves** allow you to stand in the middle of a ring. With a special ball you can even simulate **bowling**.

Words

- **accelometre** = something that records how fast you move a part of your body
- **accessory** = pieces that you can use with the game
- **accurate** = exact
- **activity** = action, something that you do with your body
- **advantage** = the good side of
- **angle** = the space between two lines that are not parallel; measured in degrees
- **balance** = to be in a position that you do not fall to one side; to be steady
- **balance board** = board that you keep straight by moving it all the time
- **Bluetooth** = wireless technology
- **body mass index** = a number based on a person's weight and height

- **bowling** = indoor game in which you roll a heavy ball down a track and knock down a group of pins
- **calculate** = find out something with the use of numbers
- **connect** = link
- **contain** = to be made up of
- **controller** = an object that is connected to a game console and used to play video games
- **create** = make
- **exercise** = physical activity
- **glove** = soft piece of leather that you wear on your hands
- **movement** = changing of position
- **pad** = flat object mostly made of rubber or plastic
- **patient** = an ill person
- **physical** = relating to your body
- **public** = all people
- **record** = save data
- **release** = to make public so that you can buy it in shops
- **remote** = an object that you use for controlling a machine without touching it
- **require** = need
- **sense of balance** = feeling that you can always keep your body on an object without falling down
- **sensor** = a small plate that records movements
- **shape** = form
- **shift** = change, movement
- **simulate** = to have the feeling that something is real
- **steering wheel** = round object in a car that lets you move in different directions
- **therapist** = someone who has been trained to help you after you have been ill
- **wireless** = a system of connecting computers and other machines by radio signals

MOTION PICTURES

Motion pictures – also called movies or films – belong to the most **popular** forms of **entertainment** today. Millions of people all over the world go to cinemas to **enjoy** an entertaining story and to see their favorite movie stars. The film industry is also a big **business**. Movies cost a lot of money and the people who make them hope to make a lot of **profit** and **achieve** worldwide **fame**.

Equipment

A movie camera **operates** like a normal camera but it takes 24 pictures a second. The **lens** **focuses** on a **certain spot**. Then a **shutter** opens and closes and an **image** is recorded on film.

The film itself is a roll of long thin flexible plastic that has **layers** of **light-sensitive** chemicals. Most films are 35 mm **wide**, which is the **common size** for motion pictures. A film has holes on both sides which the camera uses to move the roll **forward**.

A projector shows a finished film on a **screen**. It moves the film **forward** at 24 **frames** per second so that our eyes **register** moving **images** and not **still** ones. A **light bulb** at the back of the projector **projects** the image onto the **screen**, an area of white plastic that is **covered** with tiny glass **beads** that make it **bright**.

Film sound is **recorded** by a machine and mixed together with the film so that when actors open and close their mouths the words are heard at the right time.

People who make movies

A film made for **entertainment** **involves** many people, sometimes hundreds of them.

The producer is the **overall** manager of a film. He must **decide** if a movie is made or not, **raise** money and **hire** the **whole** team of workers and actors. He also has to make plans to show and **distribute** the finished film in cinemas around the world.

Before a film is made, a story or idea has to exist. A screenwriter writes the screenplay - the story, the words that the actors speak and **instructions** on how the action takes place. Sometimes it is **based** on a book, a play, a **real event**, or an old movie; sometimes on the original ideas of the screenwriter.

If a producer wants to make a **successful** movie he has to **hire** a good director. A famous director can get good actors and actresses to work with him. He is the most important person on the **set** and **in charge** of everything. He tells the actors what to do and **decides** how the scenes are filmed.

There are many other people a director must work with. The director of photography is a person who knows everything about cameras, **lenses** and **lighting** and uses them to **create** the **mood** and atmosphere of scenes. **Costume designers** **choose** clothes and decide what the actors wear.

A **successful** movie often **depends on** how good the actors are. They are the only people the **audience** gets into contact with. They must not only learn the words that characters speak in the screenplay but must also understand how to move and speak in a natural way.

Music is also an important element of most films. A composer writes music to **create** **mood**. Sound **editors** and producers put the right music into the correct place of the film.

Filming the movie

Some scenes are made on a sound stage of a movie studio with **scenery** that must look as **real** as possible. The **production team** builds the **set** exactly the way they want it to be shown in the film, but this costs a lot of extra money. Other scenes are made **on location** or in a place that looks like the one in the story, like in front of a **skyscraper** or at the beach or the top of a mountain.

Special effects are often important parts of action movies. Explosions are done on the **set** or in special places; sometimes smaller models of objects are built and then **enlarged** in the film. Modern effects specialists often do their work on computers and then **transfer** the effects to the film.

Scenes are not always **shot** in the **order** that they **appear** in the film. The film editor looks closely at all the **shots** that are made in the film. A scene may have been filmed from many different **angles** and **distances**. When a character speaks the film editor must **decide whether** to take the **total view** or a **close-up** of his or her face. Film editing is so important that the director works closely together with the film **editor**.

Finally the **pieces** of the original film are put together in the **right** order. They are copied to one **single** piece of film. Then sound and effects are **added**.

When a film is **completed** and ready to be shown a company is **hired** to **promote** the film and bring it to the **attention** of the people. **Ads** are put in magazines and newspapers, **commercials** are **run** on TV. The company hopes that it can bring as many **viewers** as possible into the cinemas. When the film is not shown in cinemas any more it is **recorded** on a DVD together with extras like interviews, unfinished scenes etc. and sold in shops. The production and **sales** of DVDs often bring film companies a lot of extra money.

History of motion pictures

In the late 1800s many **inventors** in England, France and the United States worked on ways to make motion pictures. Thomas Edison, an American **inventor**, made the first **motion picture viewer** in 1893. The films were very short and had to be watched through a **peephole**.

Early movies were black and white and had no sound. In the 1920s sound was **added** to movies, the first colour movies were **produced** in the late 1930s and early 1940s.

Movie became a big **business**. Hollywood, California became the centre of the American film industry because people could produce films the whole year round in a place where the weather never got too cold.

Later on the film industry in other countries **developed**. Great Britain, France and Italy became **major** film producing nations in Europe. In the past few **decades** India has become the biggest film producer in the world. Centre of the movie industry is Mumbai, which was **originally** called Bombay. The Indian film industry is often called Bollywood, a **mixture** of Bombay and Hollywood.

There are many festivals and **awards** for motion pictures. The largest festival is held in Cannes, France each year. Other important festivals **take place** in Berlin, Venice and London. The best known **awards** are the Academy Awards or Oscars. Each year the best films, actors, **foreign** films etc. **receive** the most famous **statuette** in the film industry.

Famous Directors

Steven Spielberg has made Hollywood's most successful films and is **regarded** as one of the most **successful** directors. Most of his films are actions movies. His **success** started with *Jaws* (1975), a movie about dangerous sharks attacking swimmers at a beach. *Close Encounters of the Third Kind* (1977) and *E.T.: The Extra-Terrestrial* (1982) are science fiction films about alien life. *Jurassic Park* (1993) and its **sequel**, *The Lost World* (1997) are about dinosaurs that have come back to live on a small island.

Spielberg has also **created** more **serious** works. *Schindler's List* (1993) is a powerful drama about a man who helped Jews during the **Holocaust**. Spielberg won an Oscar as the best director for the film, which also **received** an Academy Award as the best picture. *Saving Private Ryan* (1998) is a **realistic** story of **battle** during World War II.

Clint Eastwood started his career as an actor and **gained fame** in Italian westerns. Later on he played a police detective in *Dirty Harry* (1971). In *In the Line of Fire* (1993) he plays an American **secret serviceman** who must **protect** the president. **Although** he started **directing** films in the 1970s his **breakthrough** as a director came in 2004 with *Million Dollar Baby*, a story of a poor young **female** boxer, who becomes **paralysed** in her last fight. The film won the Oscar as best picture. In 2006 Eastwood **received** the prize for the best director in *Letters from Iwo Jima*.

Peter Jackson is a New Zealand film director who **gained** international **fame** for directing the *Lord of the Rings* **trilogy**, **based** on a fantasy novel by J.R.R. Tolkien. **Critics praised** the powerful storytelling and **spectacular** special effects. Jackson won the Academy Award as the best director for the last part *The Return of the King*, which won 11 Oscars including best picture.

Martin Scorsese is an American motion picture director who taught filmmaking at New York University before becoming a director. Many of his films are very **realistic** and often show **violence**. *Taxi Driver* (1976) shows the world of a violent **war veteran**. *Gangs of New York* (2002) **explores gang violence** in New York during the 1860s. *The Aviator* (2004) tells the story of Howard Hughes, a famous American **aircraft designer**. Scorsese **received** an Academy Award for best director in the Mafia film *The Departed* (2006).

George Lucas wrote and directed the science fiction fantasy *Star Wars* (1977), one of the most popular films in movie history. The film became an international success because of special effects that were used in film for the first time. Lucas also produced two **sequels** to the **trilogy** and twenty years later produced three more *Star Wars* movies.

The most successful films in history

<i>Film</i>	<i>Money Earned Worldwide in US Dollars</i>
Titanic (1997)	1 800 000 000
The Lord of the Rings: Return of the King (2003)	1 120 000 000
Pirates of the Caribbean : Dead Man's Chest (2006)	1 060 000 000
Harry Potter and the Sorcerer's Stone (2001)	968 000 000
Pirates of the Caribbean : At World's End (2007)	954 000 000
Star Wars Episode 1 : The Phantom Menace (1999)	922 000 000
The Lord of the Rings : The Two Towers (2002)	921 000 000
Jurassic Park (1993)	919 000 000
Harry Potter and the Goblet of Fire (2005)	892 000 000
Spider Man 3 (2007)	885 000 000



Words

- **Academy Award** =also called „Oscar“ ; is a prize given each year in the USA for the best film, actor, director of the industry
- **achieve** = to get something that you really want
- **ad** = something that tells you about a product and shows how good it is
- **add** =put in
- **aircraft designer** = person who plans and makes airplanes
- **alien** = living things from another world
- **although** =while
- **angle** = position from which you look at something
- **appear** = happen, are shown
- **attention** =the interest that you show
- **audience** = the people who go to a cinema and watch a film
- **award** = a prize that someone gets for doing something special
- **based on** =to use something from which something else is developed
- **battle** = a fight between armies in a war
- **bead** =one of a set of small round pieces of glass, wood or plastic that you where around your neck or arm
- **breakthrough** = here: a film that made him successful for the first time
- **bright** = full of light
- **business** = here: industry
- **certain** = special
- **choose** =select, pick
- **close-up** = picture that is taken very close to someone or something so that you can see a lot of details
- **commercial** = an ad on radio or TV
- **common** = something that you can see very often
- **complete** = finish
- **costume designer** = person who makes special clothes that actors wear
- **cover** =put over
- **create** = make
- **critic** = a person who writes down what he thinks about a book or a film
- **decade** = ten years
- **decide** =make up your mind about something
- **depend on** =to be affected by something else
- **develop** = grow



- **direct** = to be in control of a film
- **distance** = space from one place to another
- **distribute** = to send to places so that it can be shown
- **editor** = person who prepares something so that it can be used
- **encounter** = to meet someone for the first time
- **enjoy** = to be happy about something and like it
- **enlarge** = to make bigger
- **entertainment** = things such as films, television, music performances etc.. that people watch or go to
- **equipment** = the tools or objects you need to do a job
- **explore** = to find out about something
- **fame** = if you are known by many people because you are successful
- **female** = about women or girls
- **finally** = in the end
- **focus on** = to see clearly
- **foreign** = from another country
- **forward** = further on
- **frame** = a single photo of a film
- **gain** = get
- **gang** = group of young people who spend a lot of time together and do bad or violent things. They also fight against other groups
- **hire** = to give someone a job
- **Holocaust** = the killing of millions of Jews by the Nazis during World War II
- **image** = picture
- **in charge** = to have control over something
- **instruction** = information on how to do something
- **inventor** = a person who makes something that has not existed before
- **involve** = to take part in something
- **layer** = a material that is between two other things
- **lens** = a curved piece of glass that makes things look bigger or clearer when you look through it
- **light bulb** = the glass part of a lamp that gives off light when it is turned on
- **lighting** = the lights that light up a room or a building
- **light-sensitive** = something that reacts easily if there is light
- **major** = big
- **mixture** = two things that make one
- **mood** = how you feel about something



- **motion picture viewer** = a machine that shows a film
- **on location** = place outside the film studio where scenes are shot
- **operate** = work
- **order** = the way things are arranged; it shows if something is first, second, third etc..
- **originally** = at first
- **overall** = generally, on the whole
- **paralyzed** = if you cannot feel or move parts of your body
- **peephole** = a small hole or opening which you can look through
- **piece** = part
- **popular** = well known
- **praise** = to say good things about something or someone
- **produce** = make
- **production team** = people responsible for making the film
- **profit** = money
- **project** = to show a picture on a screen
- **promote** = to make something popular or to get people to buy something
- **raise** = to collect from people
- **real** = not false
- **real event** = something that has really happened
- **realistic** = very real
- **receive** = get
- **record** = to make a copy of something on tape, CD or DVD
- **regard** = to think about something in a special way
- **register** = here: see
- **right** = correct
- **run** = here: to show
- **sales** = the selling of something
- **scenery** = the background of a film that is made by people
- **screen** = large area on which films are shown
- **secret serviceman** = a man that works for the government and protects it and especially the president
- **sequel** = a book or film that continues the story of an earlier one
- **serious** = not silly, not humorous
- **set** = place where part of the movie is filmed
- **shoot - shot** = here: make, film
- **shot** = scene that is filmed without stopping the camera

- **shutter** = part of a camera that opens to let light through the lens
- **single** = only one
- **size** = how big something is
- **skyscraper** = very tall building in a city
- **spectacular** = very impressive
- **spot** = place
- **statuette** = small statue
- **still** = not moving
- **success** = when you have done or finished something that you really wanted to do
- **successful** = to become popular and to make a lot of money
- **take place** = happen
- **total view** = the whole scene, everything that is in the film
- **transfer** = to put into another place
- **trilogy** = a group of three books or movies that have the same characters
- **viewer** = person who watches a film in the cinema
- **violence** = behavior that makes you hurt or kill someone
- **war veteran** = a person who has been a soldier in a war
- **whether** = if
- **whole** = all of
- **wide** = from one side of something to the other
- **works** = here: films



THEATRE

A theatre is a place where people go and see all kinds of **performances**. Most people think of a theatre as a place to see a play, where a story that is **acted out** in front of an **audience**. But there are other kinds of performances that take place in a theatre too: musicals, ballets and operas.

The theatre building

Most theatres have three parts: the stage, the **auditorium** and the **backstage** area.

The stage is the most important part of a theater. It is the place where actors and actresses **perform** a play. Most plays are performed on a **proscenium** or picture-frame stage. The **audience** can watch the play only from the front. The action takes place under a large **arch**. A **curtain** opens and closes at the beginning and end of each scene.

Sometimes the **audience** can sit on three sides of a **stage**. Some theatres have a round stage in the middle of the **auditorium** with **spectators** sitting around it. Actors get on and leave the stage through the audience.

The **auditorium** is where the audience sits. Modern theatres also have **lobbies**, **rest rooms**, cafes and bars to **offer** people more **comfort** before and after the **performance**, as well as between scenes.

The backstage area is the place where the scenes are prepared and actors and actresses get dressed. There are also **storage** and office rooms for the **staff** and theatre workers. There are rooms in which **technicians** control **lighting** and sound.

People in a theatre

Many people work together in a theatre. Every production begins with a producer – sometimes a man or a woman, sometimes a whole group of people or a **company**. Producers have a lot of things to do. They have to **collect** money for the play, get a story and a **usable script**. They must be able to work with a good team.

The director decides how the play should be performed. He **interprets** the **script**, works together with the people who make the **scenery** and costumes. The director **oversees rehearsals** and tells actors how to play their part. In modern plays a **playwright** writes the **script**.

Designers create the **scenery** that shows the time and place of the story. Lighting experts have the job of moving actors or **pieces** of the stage into the **spotlight**. Lighting effects help to **create** the atmosphere of a play.

A **casting director** takes over the job of selecting actors and actresses for the play. They must choose a person with a **suitable** voice and character for every role. Make-up artists and costume designers help make the actors look good. **Choreographers** plan dance steps and other **movements**.

Actors and actresses are the main people in the play. They must study a character's **appearance**, **speech**, **body movements** and **gestures**. Practicing this is not always easy. In order to play a role well the actor must know a lot about emotions and the feelings that someone can have. They must **concentrate** on their role and keep out everything that may **distract** them.

Scene design

Designers build the scenery on a stage. Sometimes they don't have to change it during the play. At other times **sets** have to be changed quickly during **performances**. Modern theaters have stages that can **revolve** or stages that can be **raised** or **lowered**.

Words

- **act out** = perform
- **appearance** = looks
- **arch** = a curved structure above an opening
- **audience** = the people who sit in the front and watch the play
- **auditorium** = the part of the theatre where the people sit and watch the play
- **backstage** = behind the stage, where the actors and actresses get dressed
- **body movement** = the way a person moves and the special things he does
- **casting director** = a person who chooses the right performers for a play
- **choreographer** = a person who shows the dancers the movements during a performance
- **collect** = get money from anywhere you can
- **comfort** = to be relaxed, feel good
- **company** = a business organization
- **concentrate** = focus on
- **create** = make
- **curtain** = piece of cloth that hangs from the ceiling
- **distract** = to take away your attention
- **gesture** = when you move your hands or head to show what you mean or feel
- **interpret** = to show the play the way you understand it
- **lighting** = the light in a room and how it shines on the stage and actors
- **lobby** = a large hall near the entrance
- **lower** = to move down
- **movement** = to go from one place to another
- **offer** = give
- **oversee** = supervise, watch over
- **perform** = act
- **performance** = when people act out a play or play music on a stage
- **piece** = object
- **playwright** = someone who writes the script of the play
- **proscenium** = part of a stage that is front of the curtain
- **raise** = to move up



- **rehearsal** = the time when all the people of a play practice before the performance
- **rest room** = toilet
- **revolve** = to go around in a circle
- **scenery** = the background and all the objects on a stage
- **script** = the written form of a play
- **set** = the scenery or objects that are used on a stage
- **spectator** = a person who watches an event
- **speech** = the language a person uses
- **spotlight** = a light which you can direct at someone on a stage
- **staff** = all the people who work in a theatre
- **stage** = the higher area of a theatre where the actors and actresses perform or singers sing
- **storage** = place where you keep things that you do not need
- **suitable** = right, correct
- **technicians** = people who work on and control the technical parts
- **usable** = something you can use



JAMES BOND

James Bond is an English **secret** agent who was **created** by the British **novelist** Ian Fleming. The character of Bond became **popular** not only through Fleming's books but through many movies. Bond, also known as agent 007, is an attractive man who likes women. Fleming **introduced** Bond in his first **novel** Casino Royale in 1953.

Ian Fleming

Fleming was born in 1908 into a **wealthy** Scottish family. His grandfather was a banker who, after his death, left Ian's family a **fortune**. After going to school at Eton he attended the military academy at Sandhurst, but he didn't like it there and left without becoming an officer. He continued his education in the Austrian town of Kitzbühel, where nobody his real identity.

After coming back to Britain Fleming got a job as a journalist with the **news agency** Reuters and then went into banking. Both jobs did not **please** him very much, so in May 1939 he started working for the **Foreign Office**. There he became the **assistant** of one of Britain's top **spymasters**.

During the last year of the war Fleming travelled to Jamaica to a **naval** conference. He fell in love with the island and built himself a house, which he called Goldeneye. For six years he travelled back and forth from Britain to Jamaica, where he spent the winter, met lovely women, and **enjoyed** the sunset.

He **quit** the **Foreign Office** and turned to writing. He spent his time **developing** the Bond character and leading the life that he **desired**. In the late 1950s Fleming started to suffer from bad health, probably because he was a heavy drinker and smoker. He died in 1964.

James Bond

James Bond is probably one of the most famous and longest running characters in film history. Since his first **appearance** in Dr. No (1962) the Queen's number one **spy** has travelled to more places, **romanced** more women, escaped from more dangerous situations and saved the world more times than any other **secret** agent in history.

After the war he entered the British **Secret Intelligence Service**, known as MI6, where he became a "double-0" agent with a **license** to kill. His **assignments** have taken him to volcanic islands, India, Las Vegas and even a **space station** in **orbit**. He has **charm**, loves beautiful women, and likes martinis - shaken, not **stirred**-, fine **suits** and fast cars. Most of Bond's **missions** bring him into contact with **shadowy** figures of the underworld.

Some of James Bond's enemies

- Dr. Julius No - an atomic **scientist** who lost both of his hands.
- Auric Goldfinger – a **smuggler** who wants to **obtain** all the gold in the world.
- Oddjob – Goldfinger's **henchman**
- Jaws – a strong man with steel teeth
- Elliot Carver – a media **mogul** who wants to control the world

MI6 servants

- M is the **head** of MI 6. In the first films M was a man but in the last ones Bond's boss is a woman (played by Judy Dench). M finds Bond's **habits** frustrating but respects his many talents and sends him on **missions** where all other agents have **failed**.
- Q is the head of the service's **research** centre.
He **develops** the **gadgets** and **weapons** that often save Bond's life.
- Moneypenny is M's personal secretary, known for her flirting **encounters** with Bond.

History of Bond films

Starting in 1962, Fleming's novels have been made into successful films. All 22 of them have made a **net profit** of over \$4 **billion**. Sean Connery was the first, and for many true **followers** of the series the best, Bond. He played the role in six movies from 1962 to 1971. George Lazenby took over the role for one film "On Her Majesty's Secret Service", but gave it back to Connery for one more film.

From 1973 to 1985 Roger Moore **portrayed** Bond in more like a playboy way, with more humor and less **determination** than Connery. Timothy Dalton played James Bond in two movies and Pierce Brosnan **starred** in four movies from 1995 to 2002. Daniel Craig is the present Bond, starring in Casino Royal in 2006 and A Quantum of Solace in 2008.

Bond films always have the same **ingredients**: a lot of action, car **chases**, **leaps** from high mountains, gunfights and narrow escapes.

The selection of a Bond girl is almost as important as the choice of the main character himself. She is not only beautiful but also a woman that causes Bond great trouble when he finds himself attracted to her. Some of them are real **villains** while others have their own tragic background. Bond usually wins the girl but sometimes she **betrays** him and dies.

James Bond always drives in **extravagant** cars that have included an Aston Martin, a BMW Z3 and a Lotus Esprit. He also is the first to test MI5s latest **inventions**- deadly **darts**, watches that explode and special guns.

The Bond films

Movie	Year	Main actor
Dr. No	1962	Sean Connery
From Russia with Love	1963	
Goldfinger	1964	
Thunderball	1965	
You Only Live Twice	1967	
On Her Majesty's Secret service	1969	George Lazenby
Diamonds are forever	1971	Sean Connery

Live and Let Die	1973	Roger Moore
The Man with the Golden Gun	1974	
The Spy who loved me	1977	
Moonraker	1979	
For your Eyes Only	1981	
Octopussy	1983	
A View to Kill	1985	
The Living daylights	1987	Timothy Dalton
License to Kill	1989	
Golden Eye	1995	Pierce Brosnan
Tomorrow Never Dies	1997	
The World is not Enough	1999	
Die Another Day	2002	
Casino Royale	2006	Daniel Craig
Quantum of Solace	2008	

Words

- **appearance** = to show for the first time
- **assignment** = job, mission
- **assistant** = helper
- **betray** = to be disloyal to someone who trusts you
- **billion** = one thousand million
- **charm** = something that you have that makes other people like you
- **chase** = to go after someone or follow someone
- **dart** = a pointed object that you throw or shoot as a weapon
- **desire** = like
- **determination** = to try to do something even when it is difficult
- **develop** = design, make, plan
- **encounter** = to meet, come across someone

- **extravagant** = something that is expensive and costs a lot of money
- **followers** = here: a real fan
- **Foreign Office** = the British government department that is responsible for dealing with other countries
- **gadget** = a small, cleverly made machine
- **habit** = the things you normally do
- **henchman** = the helper of someone who also does criminal or illegal things for him
- **ingredient** = the qualities you need to do something
- **invention** = a machine or a tool that someone makes for the first time
- **license** = if you are officially allowed to do something
- **mission** = job
- **mogul** = a businessman or -woman who has great power in a special industry
- **naval** = having to do with the navy
- **net profit** = the money that you get from something after all the expenses are paid
- **news agency** = an organization that collects news and gives it to radio, TV or newspapers
- **novel** = a long written story with fictional characters
- **novelist** = a person who writes a novel
- **orbit** = to go around something
- **please** = like
- **portray** = to be shown as
- **quit** = stop working as
- **research** = to study something and find out new things about it or develop something new
- **romance** = to try to make someone love you
- **secret** = something that only few people know about
- **Secret Intelligence Service** = British organization whose job it is to keep Britain safe from attack by enemies in the country
- **shadowy** = unclear, mysterious
- **smuggler** = someone who brings things illegally from one country to another
- **space station** = a large spaceship that stays in orbit around the earth
- **spy** = someone who has the job of finding out secret information about another country
- **spymaster** = big and important spy
- **stir** = to move water or another drink in a glass around with a spoon
- **suit** = a set of clothes consisting of a jacket and trousers, normally made of the same material and in the same colour
- **villain** = the main bad character in a film

BEYONCE KNOWLES

Beyoncé Knowles is one of the really multit talented entertainment stars of the **present**. She is an American singer, songwriter, record producer, **actress**, dancer and **fashion designer**. Knowles became famous as the **lead singer** of the Rhythm and Blues group *Destiny's Child*, probably the most **successful female** groups of all times.

At the age of 7 she **attended** dance school and later on became a solo singer in her church's **choir**. Together with a few of her friends she started a quartet and at first **performed** in their back yards. In 1996 the group **signed up** with Columbia records and became very **successful** in the early 2000s.

After **successful** CDs with *Destiny's Child* Beyoncé **released** her first solo Album *Dangerously in Love* in 2003. With its singles *Crazy in Love* and *Baby Boy* it rose to the top of the **charts** in the UK and America. In 2004 Knowles **earned** five **Grammy Awards**.

In 2001 Knowles turned to acting. Her most famous role came in 2006 in an **adaptation** of a Broadway musical. *Dreamgirls* is **based** on the **success** of the Supremes, a black **female** group of the 1970s. Knowles was **nominated** for two **Golden Globes** including Best **Actress**.

Beyoncé Knowles also has worked a lot for the poor and hungry people in our world. She helped form Survivor *Foundation*, an organization that **provides housing** for the **victims** of Hurricane Katrina. She also went to Ethiopia and **promised** to help poor people there. On the other hand, **animal rights organizations** have criticized her for wearing **fur**.

Words

- **actress** = a woman who acts on stage or in a film
- **adaptation** = new and changed version
- **animal rights organization** = organization that tries to help animals survive in our world
- **attend** = go to
- **based** = to be the origin of
- **chart** = the most successful songs in a country
- **choir** = a group of people who sing together
- **earn** = here: get
- **entertainment** = things such as music, TV, radio, shows and other performances that people watch
- **fashion designer** = person who designs modern clothes
- **female** = relating to a woman
- **fur** = the hairy skin of animals
- **Golden Globe** = awards like the Oscars

- **Grammy Award** = prizes that are given to singers and groups by the American music industry
- **housing** = places to live
- **lead singer** = most important singer in a group
- **nominate** = to suggest someone for a prize or award
- **perform** = act
- **present** = today
- **promise** = to say that you will do something in the future
- **provide** = give
- **release** = to bring out
- **sign up** = to put your name on a document because you want to take part in something
- **success** = when you become famous or you have done what you wanted to
- **successful** = to be very famous and earn much money
- **survivor** = a person who has escaped death and can live on
- **victim** = someone who suffers because something bad has happened to them



THE TWILIGHT SAGA

Twilight is a **series** of fantasy **novels** written by the American author Stephanie Meyer. The books have become well-known **throughout** the world and even led to the production of movies. They have been on the world's bestseller lists for many years.

Plot

Bella Swan, a beautiful young teenager moves from Phoenix, Arizona to Forks, Washington. There she falls in love with Edward Cullen, a **handsome** boy. As time goes on she finds out that Edward is a member of a vampire family that drinks blood. James, a vampire from another family tries to kill her but Edward comes to her rescue.

In *The New Moon* Bella becomes a friend with the **werewolf** Jacob, who **protects** her from Victoria, James' friend and another vampire that wants to kill Bella. When Edward believes that Bella is dead he wants to **commit suicide** in Italy but Bella **manages** to stop him. In the hands of a powerful vampire family, they are **set free** only if Bella **agrees** to become a vampire.

Eclipse is the third part of the Twilight **saga**. Victoria puts together an army of vampires to fight against the Cullen family and kill Bella. Bella has to **decide** between Edward and her friendship with James the werewolf. In the end Bella chooses Edward and **agrees** to marry him.

In the fourth part Bella is **pregnant**. She nearly dies while giving birth to her daughter, who is half vampire and half **human**. Edward injects vampire **venom** into her which turns her into a vampire and **rescues** her. A **quarrel** breaks out between the Cullen and Volturi family who think that the Bella's daughter is an **immortal** child. They can be **convinced** that Bella's daughter is not a **threat** to the family.

There are a few main **topics** in Stephanie Meyers' book. **Although** the reader feels that a real love between Bell and Edward is not possible the **couple** is more and more **drawn towards** each other. It centers on love, not death. The book is also about **escape**. When Bella learns that she can become **immortal** too she really wants to get away from her mortal world.

Words

- **agree** = to say yes
- **although** = while
- **commit suicide** = to kill yourself
- **convince** = to make a person feel that something is true
- **couple** = two people who are having a love relationship
- **drawn towards** = to move to each other
- **handsome** = very nice and good-looking
- **human** = here: half a person
- **immortal** = to live on forever
- **manage** = to somehow be able to do something
- **novel** = a long story in which characters and events are not real

- **pregnant** = to expect a baby
- **protect** = guard, defend
- **quarrel** = argument
- **rescue** = save
- **saga** = a long story with many parts
- **series** = elements that belong to the same group
- **set free** = to be free
- **threat** = danger
- **throughout** = in all of
- **topic** = subjects, themes
- **venom** = a liquid poison
- **werewolf** = a person who changes into a wolf every month when the moon is full



FERRIS WHEELS – UP INTO THE SKY

A Ferris wheel is a big **structure** made of **steel** that stands straight into the sky. Passenger **cabins** are **connected** to a moving wheel. The Ferris wheel is also called **observation** wheel because it takes passengers high up into the sky where they have a great **view** of the world around them.

The first such observation wheel was built by George Ferris, an American bridge builder. He **designed** and **constructed** a big wheel for the Chicago **Exposition** in 1893. His name was used for all the big wheels that were built later.

Ferris' first wheel was able to carry more than 2000 passengers. It was over 80 meters high and powered by two **steam engines**. The 37 cabins were able to carry 60 passengers each.

Today, Ferris wheels are big **attractions** in major cities around the world. Smaller wheels can be found at **local fairs**, carnivals or **theme parks**. The world's biggest Ferris wheel is **currently** the Singapore Flyer. The wheel reaches 165 meters into the sky and started **rotating** in 2008. An even bigger Ferris wheel is being built in Beijing, China. It is planned to reach a **height** of 208 meters and will start operation some time in 2009.

The biggest observation wheel of the western world is the London Eye. It opened on December 31, 1999 – the last day of the **millennium**. The wheel takes visitors 135 meters up and gives them a fascinating view of the British capital.

Ferris wheels have played a role in many books and films. Vienna's Riesenrad may be the star among **popular** Ferris wheels. The final scene of Graham Greene's "Third Man" plays there.

Words

- **attraction** = great sight
- **cabin** = a small room
- **construct** = build
- **design** = plan
- **exposition** = a large event where you buy and sell products
- **height** = how high something is
- **local fair** = an outdoor event, where there are machines to see, games to play and where people sell products
- **millennium** = a thousand years
- **observation** = when you watch something for a certain time
- **rotate** = to revolve, go around
- **steam engine** = a machine that produces power by burning coal to make hot water
- **steel** = a very strong metal made out of iron
- **structure** = object
- **theme park** = a place where you can have fun and where the whole park has one topic
- **view** = sight